



Tamil Nadu Police
LAUNCHING OF
SINGAPPEN SPECIAL FORCE
PROVIDING ENHANCED SECURITY TO WOMEN

Launch by

Hon'ble Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu
THIRU. C. JOSEPH VIJAY



★ **FUNCTIONS OF SINGAPPEN SPECIAL FORCE** ★

Monitoring and Patrolling
of public places for a
safer environment



Preventing harassment of
women and children in
public places



Identifying vulnerable
places and taking
remedial measures



Uniting stakeholders,
building safer communities



Ensuring police
visibility and building
confidence among
women and children



People driven movement
for a women and child
friendly society



Date: 9.6.2026, Tuesday | Time: 5.00 PM
Place : Rajarathinam Stadium, Egmore, Chennai



*FOUND A LOWER
PRICE THAN OURS?*
**GET THE PLOT
FOR JUST 1 RUPEE**

**VALID WITHIN 3 KM TRAVEL DISTANCE
FROM ALL OUR PROJECTS**

PREMIUM VILLA PLOTS ACROSS CHENNAI

FROM ₹10L - ₹3CR

KARANODAI MARKET PRICE ₹4000 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹1890 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE KSHETRA  TNRERA/2/LO/1304/2026	NEELANKARAI, ECR MARKET PRICE ₹355CR /GROUND G SQUARE PRICE ₹2.99CR /GROUND ONWARDS G SQUARE ORCHID VILLE  TN/29/LAYOUT/8016/2022	UTHANDI, ECR MARKET PRICE ₹7999 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹6500 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE TRANQUIL  TN/29/LAYOUT/4457/2023	PERUMBAKKAM MARKET PRICE ₹8000 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹6690 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE MEADOWS  TN/29/LAYOUT/3325/2024
MEDAVAKKAM MARKET PRICE ₹8000 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹6999 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE SOUTH CROWN  TNRERA/29/LO/3102/2025	S.P. KOIL MARKET PRICE ₹4000 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹1999 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE Pavillion  TN/35/LAYOUT/0724/2024	MAHABALIPURAM MARKET PRICE ₹3500 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹2299 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE DYNASTY  TN/01/REGULARIZATION - LAYOUT/023/2023	VANDALUR MARKET PRICE ₹6500 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹5199 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE REGAL PARK  TN/35/LAYOUT/0336/2025
SRIPERUMBUDUR MARKET PRICE ₹4000 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹1750 TO ₹2250 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE Unicorn  TNRERA/1/LO/0479/2026.	RED HILLS MARKET PRICE ₹4000 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹2999 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE NORTHERN ALLY  TN/29/LAYOUT/8016/2022	SHOLAVARAM MARKET PRICE ₹3500 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹1799 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE NORTHERN CROWN  TNRERA/29/LO/3108/2025	MADHAVARAM MARKET PRICE ₹12,500 /SQ. FT. G SQUARE PRICE ₹10,500 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS G SQUARE SAROVAR  TNRERA/29/LO/0682/2026

PERUNGALATHUR	PORUR	MWC	TIRUVALLUR	ARCOT
MARKET PRICE ₹7999 /SQ. FT.	MARKET PRICE ₹12800 /SQ. FT.	MARKET PRICE ₹6000 /SQ. FT.	MARKET PRICE ₹3000 /SQ. FT.	MARKET PRICE ₹1350 /SQ. FT.
G SQUARE PRICE ₹6490 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS	G SQUARE PRICE ₹8999 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS	G SQUARE PRICE ₹4499 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS	G SQUARE PRICE ₹1999 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS	G SQUARE PRICE ₹799 /SQ. FT. ONWARDS
G SQUARE AURIS  TN/01/LAYOUT/7689/2022	G SQUARE Aranya  TN/01/LAYOUT/3534/2023	G SQUARE Radial  TN/35/LAYOUT/2636/2024	G SQUARE ETERNA  TNRERA/1/LO/3907/2025	G SQUARE SARVA  TNRERA/1/LO/0475/2026



BUILD YOUR VILLA AND GET DISCOUNT UPTO

₹5 LAKHS*

OFFICIAL VILLA CONSTRUCTION PARTNER

Brick & Bolt
HOME & COMMERCIAL CONSTRUCTION

**UP TO 90%
BANK LOAN AVAILABLE**



MEMBER
CREDAI

**CASH NOT
ACCEPTED**

FOR SITE VISIT CALL

89391 70005

From Page One

No incriminating data found in hard disks stolen from TNPDC

The case was transferred by Director-General of Police and Head of Police Force Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal, given its sensitive nature, police sources said. The theft led to speculation that it was a deliberate attempt to erase or tamper with evidence in an alleged multi-crore scam in the TNPDC or in its allied organisations. A top official in Tangedco said that besides a data protection policy, strict access control measures were in place to secure the vital assets of the company.

Tender corruption case

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case of alleged corruption in the tenders floated by Tangedco for the supply of distribution transformers during 2021, 2022, and 2023. Acting on the direction of the Madras High Court, the CBI booked a case to probe the allegations of corruption that had resulted in unjust enrichment of bidders and a corresponding loss to the exchequer to the tune of ₹397 crore.

The CBI's Anti-Corruption Branch invoked provisions of the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988, and booked the case against the then officials of Tangedco's Tender Inviting Authority and Tender Scrutiny Committee, and others.

The complainants in the case were Jayaraman Venkatesan, managing trustee, Arappor lyakkam; E. Saravanan, deputy secretary, AIADMK Advocates' Wing, Salem; and Rajkumar of Meikilarpatti in Usilampatti taluk of Madurai district.

INBRIEF



Heads of sugar mills sector call on Vijay at Secretariat

The South Indian Sugar Mills Association office-bearers called on Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay at the Secretariat in Chennai on Monday. Association president (T.N.) R. Varadharajan, Rajshree Pathy, chairperson, Rajshree Sugars and Chemicals, M. Manickam, chairman and managing director of Sakthi Sugars, Muthiah Murgappan, CEO of the EID Parry (India), Arjun Kothari, managing director, Kothari Sugars and Chemicals, N. Ramanathan, managing director, Ponni Sugars, M. Silvester, director, Kothari Sugars, A.H. Ashiq, chief operating officer, EID Parry, Aditya Pathi, chief strategy officer, Rajshree Sugars and Chemicals, and G. Sathyamurthy, president of the company, were present, a press release said.



Chief Minister plays chess with Praggnanandhaa

When Grandmaster Praggnanandhaa arrived at the Secretariat in Chennai on Monday to meet Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, he did not expect what was in store for him: the Chief Minister immediately asked officials to bring a chessboard and played a game with him. "I did not expect it. He [Mr. Vijay] asked officials to bring a board and started playing with me. I did not know he would play chess. Though I won, he played well. He told me that he often plays with his friends," said the Grandmaster. Photos and videos of the Chief Minister playing chess with Praggnanandhaa have drawn widespread attention on social media and among chess enthusiasts. Mr. Vijay also presented a cheque for ₹50 lakh to him.

Take alternative measures for farming in delta: Dhinakaran

AMMK general secretary T.T.V. Dhinakaran on Monday called upon the State government to make alternative arrangements for agricultural operations in the Cauvery delta as there was little likelihood of the Mettur dam being opened on the scheduled date of June 12. In a social media post, Mr. Dhinakaran referred to the demand of the farmers for a special *Kuruvai* package and supply of uninterrupted three-phase electricity. Mr. Dhinakaran said that during his next visit to New Delhi, Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay should call upon the Congress leadership to take up with Karnataka Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar the release Tamil Nadu's share of Cauvery water.

Foreign nationals of Indian origin who left soon after T.N. elections come under scanner

Central, State law enforcement agencies have been working with the EC to obtain data on foreign nationals who might have voted. Investigators have also sought the help of Bureau of Immigration

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

After detecting around 40 cases of foreign nationals of Indian origin allegedly voting in the recent Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, investigators have shifted their focus to those who returned abroad shortly after the April 23 polling.

According to official sources, Central and State law-enforcement agencies are working with the Election Commission of India (EC) to obtain data on suspected foreign nationals who might have voted in the election. Investigators have sought the assistance of the Bureau of Immigration, Government of India, in identifying foreign nationals who arrived in the State ahead of the election and departed within two to three days of polling.

Probing social media

The authorities are also verifying social media posts and videos in which individuals claimed to have travelled to Chennai, Ben-



Final call: Any decision on the validity of the votes cast by foreign nationals in the Assembly elections will have to be taken by the EC, says a senior State government official. FILE PHOTO

galuru, and other cities, specifically to exercise franchise. "It is possible to verify whether these individuals voted in the Assembly election. If they did, it would amount to cheating and violation of provisions of the Representation of the People Act, 1951. We are also examining how their names were not removed from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR). If a voter is falsely shown to be residing in India, action will be taken against those responsible

for making the false declaration," a senior State government official told *The Hindu* on Monday.

The first case of alleged illegal voting came to light in the second week of May when a couple were questioned by immigration officials at the Madurai airport while preparing to board a flight to Colombo. Questioned about the indelible ink marks on their fingers, they admitted to having voted in the election using their Electors Photo Identity Cards (EPICs). They were subsequently handed

over to the Avaniapuram police.

In another case, a United Kingdom national of Indian origin was detained at the Chennai airport after admitting that he had voted in the Velachery constituency. He was handed over to the local police for further investigation.

"During the SIR, family members appear to have filled the enumeration form and signed it on behalf of the foreign national. This would amount to a false declaration. Proceedings will be initiated through appropriate channels against the individuals who voted and then left the country," the official said.

Apart from prosecution for fraudulent voting, foreign nationals found to have voted in the election could face cancellation of their Overseas Citizen of India (OCI) cards, the official said. He added that any decision on the validity of the votes cast by foreign nationals in the Assembly election would have to be taken by the EC.

Eligible SC/ST families will get pattas within 5 years: Minister

B. Kolappan
N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

Minister for Social Justice Vanni Arasu on Monday said the government's objective was to ensure house *pattas* for every eligible SC/ST family within the next five years. The Minister, on Monday, chaired a meeting with the officials of his department.

He said the initiative to grant house *e-pattas* was among the government's top priorities and would be implemented after consultations with Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay. "It is unfor-

tunate and tragic that even decades after India attained Independence, many SC/ST families still do not possess house *pattas*. We are committed to ensuring that every deserving beneficiary receives one," the Minister, a VCK representative in the TVK-led coalition government, told *The Hindu* on Monday.

Mr. Arasu said he was confident of achieving the goal as the Chief Minister had made it clear that Ministers should function independently, eradicate corruption at all levels, and provide clean governance. He briefly took a break



Vanni Arasu

from meeting a steady stream of visitors to his office to discuss his plans. People from across the State had come seeking assistance not only in matters relating to the Social Justice Department but also other departments.

"Sometimes, I have to personally approach the Minister concerned on behalf of those who come to me seeking help," he said. The Minister said he spent weekends travelling across the State to gain first-hand knowledge of issues on the ground.

Referring to the recommendations of the Justice Chandru Committee, constituted by the previous DMK government to suggest measures to prevent caste- and creed-based conflicts among school and college students and promote social harmony, he said the government would

Poll strategy of Cong. weakened TMC, DMK, and CPI(M): VCK chief

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

VCK president Thol. Thirumavalavan on Monday criticised the Congress' "electoral strategy" and "approach", saying it had weakened the Trinamool Congress, CPI(M), and the DMK in West Bengal, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu respectively.

At a meeting of the INDIA bloc in New Delhi, Mr. Thirumavalavan said the Congress' approach had caused dissatisfaction among several constituents of the INDIA bloc. A copy of his speech was circulated in the media in Chennai.

Mr. Thirumavalavan said: "To effectively carry forward such struggles, mutual trust, understanding, and unity among opposition parties are indispensable. In particular, the Congress' electoral strategy in Kerala, West Bengal, and Tamil Nadu weakened parties that have been among the strongest pillars of this alliance. This is neither desirable nor beneficial to the larger cause of opposition unity. The Congress must therefore undertake a sincere reassessment of its approach and explore ways to further

strengthen and consolidate the alliance."

"The responsibility for maintaining unity rests not only with regional parties but equally with national parties. At a time when Centre-State relations are under unprecedented strain, national parties must re-evaluate their positions through the lens of federalism and cooperative governance," he said.

Criticising the BJP's "mishandling" of the education sector, Mr. Thirumavalavan referred to the "series of question paper leaks that had led to the cancellation and re-conduct of major examinations, exposing widespread irregularities and systemic failures".

"The present situation has arisen in part because we, as political forces, have failed to consistently mobilise and fight for the issues confronting the youth. We should not regard Cockroach Janta Party, an organisation that raises the concerns of youths, as an adversary. Instead, the INDIA bloc must take up these issues on a broader platform, amplify the voices of the youths, and launch coordinated nationwide protests," he added.

YouTube Maridhas held for making 'derogatory' remarks

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI/MADURAI

YouTube Maridhas was arrested in Madurai on Monday in a case registered by the Chennai Cyber Crime Wing on charges of posting "derogatory and obscene" remarks on social media about a woman Minister in Tamil Nadu.

He was picked up by a special team of the Greater Chennai Police in Madurai and brought to Chennai later. The police said he published videos and posts against Ministers, including a woman member of the Cabinet headed by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay.

Statements against TVK

The police said he also made remarks against ruling TVK functionaries. The team, along with the Madurai City police, had deployed heavy security around Maridhas' house at Surya Nagar in Madurai.

The police book Maridhas under various sections of the Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita, as well as provisions of the Information Technology Act.

Pay ₹10 lakh each to 3 child victims of sexual offence, orders Madras HC

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Stressing the need for trial courts to order adequate monetary compensation to child victims of sexual offences who have to undergo therapy for post-traumatic stress disorder, the Madras High Court has ordered the payment of ₹10 lakh each to three minor boys who were subjected to aggravated penetrative sexual assault by their fathers for a long period of time.

Justice A.D. Jagadish Chandira allowed a criminal appeal filed by the mother of two of the victims and held that all three victims would be entitled to the maximum compensation of ₹10 lakh each. The appeal had been preferred against the failure of a special court for Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act cases to award sufficient compensation in the case. The petitioner's counsel, Deepika Murali, told the court that the appellant and her husband had two children. The appellant's younger sister had married her husband's younger brother, and the couple had one son. All of them



The judge ordered that the compensation be paid to the victims within 30 days.

resided together in Saudi Arabia.

In 2018, the appellant caught her brother-in-law showing pornographic visuals on his mobile phone to the three children. Though she took up the issue with her husband, he refused to confront his younger brother. Subsequently, the appellant learnt that her husband was also having an illicit affair with multiple women, and therefore, decided to part ways with him. During the same period, the appellant noticed burns on her younger son's body, but the child refused to reveal the cause. However, her sister's son disclosed that those injuries were caused by the appellant's

husband and his brother, who used to give stupefying agents to the children and force them to cooperate for sex. The appellant and her sister returned to India with their three children.

In 2019, the appellant's husband and his brother came to India and convinced their wives' parents to send their spouses and their children to their residence. The trauma continued there, with the brothers subjecting the children to aggravated penetrative sexual assault. Hence, the appellant chose to lodge a police complaint on April 16, 2019. The police took two years to complete the investigation. They filed a charge-sheet only on September 3, 2021. Finally, the trial court on January 29, 2025, convicted the brothers under the POCSO Act and sentenced them to 20 years of rigorous imprisonment. The two convicts' youngest brother and their mother were sentenced to three years of rigorous imprisonment.

The trial court found that the children's testimony corroborated the medical evidence.

After taking note that the children had been paid

an interim compensation of ₹25,000 each in 2021, the trial judge imposed a fine of ₹1.5 lakh each on the two prime convicts, besides ₹30,000 each on the other two convicts, and ordered that the victims should be entitled to that money too as compensation if the convicts choose to pay the fine without undergoing the default sentence.

Not in agreement with the trial court's course of action, Justice Chandira said the children would be in need of a substantial amount of money for medical expenses. He said it was essential for them to undergo therapy to overcome the tendency of having recurrent flashbacks of the horrifying events and lead a normal life by maintaining healthy relationships with others.

The judge found that two Government Orders, issued on October 3, 2020, and July 10, 2021, provide for a maximum amount of ₹10 lakh under the Tamil Nadu Child Victim Compensation Fund. Hence, he ordered that each of the three victims be paid ₹10 lakh each, after adjusting the interim compensation amount, within 30 days.

CPI to take a call on tie-up with DMK this week, says Veerapandian

The Hindu Bureau
KRISHNAGIRI

The CPI will take a decision on continuing in the DMK-led alliance at the conclusion of the party's executive and administrative committee meetings to be held this week, its State secretary M. Veerapandian said in Denkanikottai on Monday. On the sidelines of CPI-led protests against eviction orders issued by the Hindu Religious and Endowments Board to decades-old settlements on *poramboke* lands, he fielded queries from mediapersons on speculations of his party's continuance in the DMK-led alliance on the heels of CPI(M) State secretary P. Shanmugam's saying the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance did not exist. He said that was the CPI(M)'s stand, while the CPI would make an "authoritative" announcement after the executive and administrative committee meetings, scheduled from June 9 to 11.

Mr. Veerapandian reiterated that the Left parties were very much still a part of the INDIA bloc.

INBRIEF



Union demands increase in wages for contract workers

Chennai Metropolitan Water Supply and Sewerage Board Labourers' Union urged the State government to provide permanent jobs and better wages to Metrowater contract labourers. Office-bearers of the union met Gagandeep Singh Bedi, Additional Chief Secretary, Municipal Administration and Water Supply Department, on Monday regarding various demands. G. Beem Rao, former Maduravoyal MLA and the union's president said permanent jobs must be provided to workers who have completed 480 days of service. Besides implementing the old pension scheme and providing double wages for overtime work, the workers must also be extended other benefits like Provident Fund and Employees' State Insurance.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (June 9, Tuesday), the following articles are available:

■ What is lost and gained in NFHS-6
newsth.live/healthsurvey

■ Technique to 'amplify' random numbers is digital security breakthrough
newsth.live/randomnumbers

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

Thundershowers may bring down prolonged heat in northern districts

The Southwest monsoon is likely to advance further in the State in the next two days, and the Regional Meteorological Centre predicts that isolated heavy rain may continue over interior districts and the Western Ghats districts till June 11

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Northern districts, including Vellore and Chennai, reeling under heat may receive moderate rainfall on Tuesday. After another sizzling day on Tuesday, maximum temperatures are expected to stay close to normal from Wednesday.

Various places, particularly the coastal region, have been reeling under above normal temperatures well into June. On Monday, Chennai's Mee-nambakkam recorded 39.7 degrees Celsius, the hottest temperature for the day in the State. It was closely followed by Cuddalore and Parangipettai with 39.4 degrees Celsius, Vellore with 39.3 degrees Celsius and Chennai Nungambakkam, Tondi and Tiruttani with 39 degrees Celsius.

As the Southwest monsoon is likely to advance further over Tamil Nadu in the next two or three days, the Regional Meteorological Centre has predicted



Monsoon effect: Dark clouds hover over Nungambakkam in the city on Sunday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

that isolated heavy rainfall may continue over interior districts of the State and Western Ghats districts till June 11. On Monday too, places including Valparai and Kanniyakumari recorded rainfall till 6 p.m.

On Tuesday, the RMC had forecast that moderate rainfall may occur in north districts, including Vellore, Ranipet, Chennai and its neighbouring districts. Ten

districts, including Nilgiris, Theni, and Dharmapuri, may experience heavy rainfall with gusty winds reaching a speed of 40-50 kmph.

The RMC has also warned that residents of north interior Tamil Nadu and coastal areas may experience discomfort and heat stress on Tuesday owing to high maximum temperature and elevated level

los of humidity.

V.R. Durai, Director, Regional Weather Forecasting Centre, RMC, said strong westerlies and lack of sea breeze during daytime led to hot weather conditions, particularly in the coastal region. While daytime may be hot and humid, thundershower activity is expected in the evening over north Tamil Nadu districts on Tuesday.

Adyar Cancer Institute offers free robotic surgeries

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Nearly 60% of the robotic-assisted cancer surgeries done at The Adyar Cancer Institute have been done under free and subsidised treatment programmes.

The procedures cover thoracic, head and neck, colorectal, urological and gynaecological cancers, and are performed using the da Vinci Surgical System.

The institute has also developed expertise in transoral robotic surgery (TORS) for head and neck cancers, available in a limited number of centres in India. All cases are reviewed by multidisciplinary tumour boards.

Robotic-assisted cancer surgery has been made more accessible through institutional support, donor funding and a subsidised care model, while maintaining clinical selection criteria.

Arvind Krishnamurthy, Deputy Medical Director and Head of Surgical Oncology, said the programme has enabled access to advanced surgery for patients from lower and middle-income groups.

Lighting, CCTV camera surveillance at Marina beach to be enhanced

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Corporation Commissioner G.S. Sameeran and City Police Commissioner A. Amalraj conducted an inspection on Marina beach to improve lighting for the safety and security of visitors.

The civic body is planning to install solar-based lighting and additional CCTV cameras at the beach.



Focus on safety: Greater Chennai City Police Commissioner A. Amalraj and GCC Commissioner G.S. Sameeran inspecting Marina beach in Chennai on Monday. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Turtle nesting

Mr. Sameeran said: "The GCC and the police will assess the requirement of lighting and CCTV. The solar-based mild lighting will not affect nesting of olive ridley turtles. The fittings will be installed 100 metres beyond the high tide line."

The civic agency will in-

crease light fittings and CCTV cameras to facilitate rescue operations by lifeguards.

During the joint inspection on Monday evening, the officials assessed the effectiveness of the watch tower, identified CCTV black spots, and checked

the all-terrain vehicles.

The GCC is operating one all-terrain vehicle for surveillance while the police are maintaining another all-terrain vehicle for rescue of visitors. The GCC will conduct a survey to assess safety and security issues pertaining to the Mari-

na beach and submit a report shortly.

As visitors have demanded that civic agencies remove restrictions to visiting the beach during night, the civic body is also exploring the feasibility of permitting visitors round the clock.

2 killed after lorry rams two-wheelers

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Two men were killed after a lorry carrying ration supplies rammed multiple two-wheelers near Basin Bridge on Monday morning.

The deceased were identified as Additional Registrar at the Madras High Court N. Muralidharan, 56, of Mogappair, and Gowtham, 60, of Avadi, who worked for a private company.

The accident occurred at the Moolakothalam junction on Tiruvottiyur High Road when several vehicles were waiting at a traffic signal.

Rajeswari, 45 and Balakrishnan, 62, sustained injuries in the accident and are undergoing treatment.

The lorry driver, Rajkumar, 46, of Koyambedu, was arrested. A case was registered. Preliminary inquiries suggest that the vehicle might have suffered brake failure.

Timings
CHENNAI

TUESDAY, JUN. 09		
RISE	05:43	SET 18:35
RISE	00:32	SET 12:54
WEDNESDAY, JUN. 10		
RISE	05:43	SET 18:35
RISE	01:11	SET 13:46
THURSDAY, JUN. 11		
RISE	05:43	SET 18:35
RISE	01:52	SET 14:42

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	30	28
Chennai Airport	40	30
Chennai City	39	30

Chennai Airport Today 40°C The weather will be hot and uneasy. The night will also be uneasy. A spell of light rain and thundershowers may occur.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow 39°C The morning will be comfortable. The day will be hot and uneasy. The night also will be uneasy. There are chances of light rain and thundershowers.

© Copyright Skymet Weather 2026
All rights reserved.

THE HINDU

DISCLAIMER: Readers are requested to verify and make appropriate enquires to satisfy themselves about the veracity of an advertisement before responding to any published in this newspaper. THE PUBLISHER, PVT. LTD., the Publisher & Owner of this newspaper, does not vouch for the authenticity of any advertisement or advertiser or for any of the advertiser's products and/or services. In no event can the Owner, Publisher, Printer, Editor, Director/s, Employees of this newspaper/company be held responsible/liable in any manner whatsoever for any claims and/or damages for advertisements in this newspaper.

Members of AISF detained while staging protest before CBSE office

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Greater Chennai Police detained 16 members of the All India Students' Federation (AISF), when they

staged a protest in front of the CBSE regional office in Anna Nagar on Monday without prior permission. They were later released.

The protesters demanded the resignation of Union

Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, alleging irregularities in CBSE examinations and the NEET question paper leak. They carried slogans critical of the Union government.

**CBIC TUMAKURU INDUSTRIAL TOWNSHIP LIMITED**
(A Joint Venture of Government of India and Government of Karnataka)
Communication Office: #2, 2/1 & 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar, Bengaluru - 560009. Ph: +91-80-22265383, Email:mdcbic24@gmail.com

No:CBICTITL/ENG/ETND-DPR-01/664/2026-27 **Date:08-06-2026**

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

CBIC-TITL invites tender from reputed consultants/firms under two cover bid system having an office at Bengaluru with vast experience and proven record of similar nature of work for project mentioned below:-
Name of the work: Providing Consultancy Services for Survey, Investigation, Design, Estimate and Preparation of Detailed Project Report (DPR) for Water Supply Scheme from Vanivilas Sagara Dam to Tumakuru Industrial Township (CBIC) via Metturke Industrial Area and Sira Industrial Area, (2nd Cal)

● Last Date and Time for Receipt of Tenders: **20-06-2026 upto 4:00 pm.**

Applicants May download bidding documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement portal
https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in

Sd/- Engineer-In-Chief
CBIC-TITL

DIPR/CP/1054/CCL/2026-27

CLASSIFIEDS MART

TO ADVERTISE VISIT
www.thehinduads.com
CALL: 044-28576300 ■ TOLL FREE: 1800 102 4161
or Contact your nearest Authorised space sellers

PERSONAL
CHANGE OF NAME
I, AJITHESH Koushik Prakash born on 30/10/2006, S/O Ranganathan Prakash residing at Plot No 14/15, Door No 16 Flat 3A RAMS Casa Terra Srinivasapuram Main Road ,Thiruvanniyur Chennai 600041 Shall hence forth be known as Ajithesh Kausthik Prakash.

PERSONAL
OLD AGE HOME
PALLIATIVE CARE at your home Trained Nurses, 24/7, Dr., Physio visits, Lab tests 1800-313-1883 tikotra.com/seniors

PEST CONTROL
NETLON SAINTGOBAIN SS Doortype SV Trading Authorised Dealer:9940386715

HOME NEEDS
Parryware
always in fashion
BATHROOM RENOVATION
From Professional Bathroom Makers Since 2001
FRIENDLY SERVICES
Call Now:
044 - 2432 3144
98412-95033
98412-78121
T.Nagar, Chennai - 600 017.

LOST & FOUND
LOST & FOUND- I, N. BHURALAL would like to inform the General Public that i have misplaced my Original Sale Deed Doc No.4583/2006, Registered at Pallavaram SRO. If anyone finds, kindly contact 9882916916 with in 15 days from the date off issue of this Ad.

CORRIGENDUM

With reference to the L&T AGM advertisement published on 6 June 2026, it is clarified that, in the Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft programme, L&T executed its scope in a contracted role for Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE), which is the design authority for the project.

We regret any unintended ambiguity and confusion caused.

Larsen & Toubro Limited

CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4.
RTP concerts Today at 5 pm
Chief Guest: SRI PALGHAT RAJARAMAN - DHANYA DINESH RUDRAPATNAM - VOCAL, R Naveen - Violin, T Karthik - Mrdangam. 6.30 pm SANGEETHA BHAKTHI SAMARPANAM, S Varadarajan - Violin, Neyveli Narayanan - Mrdangam, Palghat V Suresh - Ghatam. Ph. No: 86103 57987. Rasikas welcome

To advertise visit
www.thehinduads.com
☎ 044-28576300
☎ Toll Free
1800 102 4161

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Dr. Mrs. MANI KRISHNASWAMI FOUNDATION CHENNAI
Warmly invites the gracious presence of family and friends at the celebration of **"SRI. M.KRISHNASWAMI ("MK") CENTENARY YEAR 2026"**



The Celebration will be followed by
"THE MANI and MK ANNUAL AWARD CEREMONY 2026"
"LIFETIME ACHIEVEMENT AWARD" conferred upon
Sangitha Kalanidhi / Padma Shri / Tirupati Asthana Vidushi
Avasara! Kanyakumari

Wednesday 10 June 2026 @ Raga Sudha Hall, Luz Church Road, Mylapore
PROGRAM COMMENCES AT 4 PM
Screening of short video on **"MK the Man for all Seasons"**
TRIBUTES TO "MK"
T.K.Balaji (Chairman & M.D., LUCAS-TVS)
T.S.Krishnamurthy (former Chief Election Commissioner of India)
Sangitha Kalanidhi A.Kanyakumari
P.Prabhakar Rao (Advisor, The Sanmar Group)
P.Nityananda Rao (Mani Krishnaswami Academy, Mangalore)
Members of MK Family
Felicitations to A.Kanyakumari Suguna Varadachari & T.S.Krishnamurthy
Violin Kutcheri: Sangitha Kalanidhi A.Kanyakumari

*** Demise after 9th June 2025**

Kochi court allows ED access to documents in CMRL pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

A special court for the trial of Companies Act offences in Kochi on Monday allowed the Enforcement Directorate (ED) to obtain copies of documents collected by the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) in connection with the money laundering case linked to the Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL) pay-off case.

Ernakulam Additional District and Sessions Judge V.P.M. Suresh Babu allowed a petition filed by the Enforcement Directorate seeking copies of documents gathered by the SFIO, which had investigated the alleged fictitious expenses submitted by the CMRL before the Income Tax Settlement Commission.

The Enforcement Directorate on May 27 searched the residences of former Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan in Kannur and Thiruvananthapuram as part of the probe into whether his daughter and former IT consultant T. Veena's now-defunct firm Exalogic had received sizeable monthly retainers from the CMRL, a private mining company, during the 2017-2021 period allegedly without rendering any tangible service.

The Central agency had reportedly sought 134 documents collected by the SFIO during its probe into the links between the CMRL and Ms. Veena's firm, which allegedly offered IT consultancy to the



T. Veena

Kochi-based company. The petition, filed on June 6, came up for consideration before the court on Monday. The CMRL opposed the plea stating that the documents should not be handed over to the Enforcement Directorate without hearing it.

However, the court allowed the petition after hearing submissions from the ED, SFIO, and CMRL.

'Fraudulent operations'
The SFIO had informed the court that Ms. Veena had colluded with Sasidharan Kartha, Chairman and Managing Director of the CMRL, to "siphon off ₹2.78 crore from the company, misrepresenting the payments as IT consultancy fee for services that were not delivered."

She played a pivotal role in the fraudulent operations totalling ₹2.78 crore from the CMRL under the guise of IT consultancy services, it said.

The SFIO had arraigned her as the 11th accused in the final complaint filed before the Additional Sessions Court-7, Ernakulam.

Deve Gowda nearing end of six-decade-long stint in public office

Ex-PM's tenure in Rajya Sabha comes to an end on June 25; Karnataka BJP has fielded its own leader for RS polls instead of the 93-year-old

Sharath S. Srivatsa
BENGALURU

The former Prime Minister and Janata Dal (Secular) supremo, H.D. Deve Gowda, is set to end his more than six-decades-long political career in public office with his tenure as a Rajya Sabha member coming to an end on June 25.

While all eyes were on the BJP's move, the party late on Sunday night decided to nominate M. Nagara-ja from its ranks instead of the nonagenarian leader, its ally in the National Democratic Alliance (NDA).

With the retirement of the 93-year-old leader, known for his knowledge in agriculture and irrigation, especially the Cauvery river dispute, Parliament will now not have any former Prime Ministers as a member.

Vokkaliga politics

The JD(S) was hoping that Mr. Gowda, who is respected by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, will be nominated to the Rajya Sabha. Besides, with another Vokkaliga leader D.K. Shivakumar becoming Chief Minister, it was speculated that the BJP could offer its seat to Mr. Gowda as a counterweight in the Vokkaliga politics that dominates the Old Mysuru region.

However, the BJP State



Former PM H.D. Deve Gowda has said that he will remain in active politics till his end.

Deve Gowda became 14th Chief Minister of Karnataka in 1994 and 11th Prime Minister in 1996 heading United Front

unit had insisted on fielding a party leader.

"This was not our election because we did not have the numbers. We had not asked for it either. There is no question of dis-appointment. This was not our seat," sources in the JD (S) told *The Hindu*. "We are not attaching too much importance. This is media speculation."

In the election to four Rajya Sabha seats set to be held on June 18, the Congress has the numbers to win three and the BJP one. The JD(S) with 18 legislators does not have the

numbers and was dependent on the BJP's decision.

Active till the end

On multiple occasions in the past, Mr. Gowda, whose understanding of the regional caste equations are well known, has said that he would remain in active politics till his end.

The current stint had been made possible by the Congress's decision to support him in the 2020 Rajya Sabha elections that came after his defeat in Karnataka's Tumakuru Lok Sabha constituency during the 2019 election, when the JD (S) faced the election in alliance with the Congress.

Soon after the party's debacle in the 2023 Assembly elections, the JD(S) joined the NDA.

During his illustrious political career that started from being elected to the Taluk Development Board in 1960 and later to the Karnataka Legislative Assembly in 1962, Mr. Gowda became the 14th Chief Minister of Karnataka in 1994 after leading the Janata Dal to victory and the 11th Prime Minister in 1996 heading the United Front government.

He has been a six-term member of the Lok Sabha and a two-term member in the Rajya Sabha. He has been elected to the Legislative Assembly seven times.

Free bus for women in Kerala initially for ordinary services

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The first phase of the free travel scheme for women on Kerala State Road Transport Corporation (KSRTC) buses will be implemented in ordinary services. In Kerala, for the first 100 days of the scheme, women will be allowed to travel free only on ordinary buses. After this period, the State government is actively considering extending the free travel benefit to more services, including fast and superfast buses, Transport Minister C.P. John said after a meeting with Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan on Monday.

The travel concession for women, which was among the key 'Indira Guarantees' promised by the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) in its Assembly election manifesto, is set to be implemented in the State from June 15.

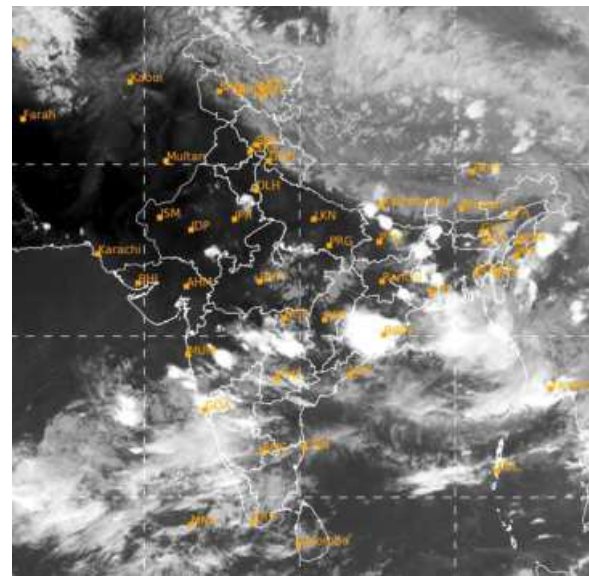
The Finance Secretary has been tasked with studying how to compensate the KSRTC for the revenue loss resulting from the implementation of the scheme.

Liabilities

An expert committee appointed by the transport utility had assessed that allowing free travel on higher-category buses, including fast passenger and long-haul services, from the beginning would cause significant practical difficulties and revenue losses.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 18.15 HRS)

Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Telangana, Maharashtra, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Kerala, Mahe and Lakshadweep. Heat wave conditions likely at isolated places over Rajasthan, Jammu & Kashmir, Punjab, Delhi and Uttar Pradesh

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	9	35.2	26.2	Kurnool	0.6	35.5	25.7
Ahmedabad	0	42.2	29.9	Lucknow	0	40.3	29.7
Aizawl	0	32.1	24.3	Madurai	0	34.7	27.1
Bengaluru	11	29.6	21.2	Mangaluru	3	28.8	24.8
Bhopal	0	38.7	25.8	Mumbai	0	35.1	29.9
Bhubaneswar	12.9	40.7	26.2	Mysuru	0	31.2	20.4
Chandigarh	0	41.0	25.8	New Delhi	0	42.2	29.2
Chennai	0	39.7	30.0	Patna	0	41.3	30.3
Coimbatore	0	29.8	23.4	Port Blair	0.8	31.5	27.3
Dehradun	0	37.0	23.8	Prayagraj	0	42.5	28.0
Gangtok	8	23.5	17.8	Puducherry	0	38.8	26.6
Goa	0	31.4	24.7	Pune	0	35.6	25.8
Guwahati	0	34.7	27.0	Raipur	0	42.0	32.2
Hubballi	0	26.0	23.0	Ranchi	0	37.2	23.0
Hyderabad	0	36.4	25.2	Shillong	0	26.0	18.0
Imphal	0.8	31.1	23.1	Shimla	0	30.8	21.0
Jaipur	0	40.1	27.2	Srinagar	0	30.3	12.5
Kochi	34	29.4	24.2	Thiruvananthapuram	51	30.5	22.7
Kohima	23	25.0	19.0	Tiruchirappalli	0	36.3	27.4
Kolkata	0	38.0	24.6	Vijayawada	6	37.4	25.6
Kozhikode	2	32.0	26.2	Visakhapatnam	0	35.3	20.3

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing	Yesterday
CITIES	SO₂ NO₂ CO PM2.5 PM10 CODE
Ahmedabad	85 32 43 74 86
Bengaluru	16 19 44 31 47
Chennai	6 14 52 40 52
Delhi	28 62 48 104 394
Hyderabad	13 18 35 81 86
Kolkata	14 25 17 71 83
Lucknow	12 12 47 160 98
Mumbai	4 6 41 27 108
Pune	48 65 47 85
Visakhapatnam	18 48 17 55 128

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Your feedback will keep us Cleaner, Sharper and Bolder

Call our toll-free number
1800 102 1878

Or write to us at
customercare@thehindu.co.in

Scan the QR code to register your feedback

THE HINDU thehindubusinessline.
FRONTLINE SPORTSTAR youngworld THE HINDU

THE HINDU

Air Surcharge as applicable:
New Delhi - Rs. 15/-
Port Blair - Rs. 20/-

S. E. RAILWAY - TENDER

For & on behalf of President of India the General Manager (Engg.), South Eastern Railway, Garden Reach, Kolkata-700043 invites e-tender for the following work:
Tender No.: BR-HQ-KGP-26-27-02, Date: 04.06.2026, Description of the work: Kharagpur Division—Conversion of existing bridges into Composite girders/Balasted decks for running of 25T Axle loaded freight trains @ 100Kmph in (a) Bridge No. 69 DN (Span 4x18.3m) in between station Ghatsila-Dhalbhumgarh Bridge No. 94UP (Span 2x 18.3m) in between station Jhargam-Gidhni, (b) Bridge No. 217 UP (Span 9x18.3m) in between station Raighat-Amarda Road, (c) Bridge No. 235 UP (Span 9x18.3m) in between station Basta-Nuaogaon Mayurbhanj Road, (d) Bridge No. 235 DN (Span 9x18.3m) in between station Nuaogaon Mayurbhanj Road-Basta, (e) Bridge No. 264UP (Span 9x18.3m) in between station Haldipada-Balasore, (f) Bridge No. 238 UP (Span 3x12.2m) in between station Nuaogaon Mayurbhanj Road-Rupsa & Bridge No. 239 UP (Span 2x12.2m+2x18.3m) in between Nuaogaon Mayurbhanj Road-Rupsa, (g) Bridge 239 DN (Span 2x12.2m+2x18.3m) in between station Rupsa-Nuaogaon Mayurbhanj Road & Bridge No. 239 UP (Span 4x12.2m) in between station Haldipada-Balasore, (h) Bridge No. 217 DN (Span 9x18.3m) in between station Amarda Road-Raighat & Br. No. 234UP (Span 5x12.2m) in between station Basta-Nuaogaon Mayurbhanj Road, (i) Bridge No. 168DN (Span 4x12.2m+2x18.3m) in between station Bakhrabad-Narayangarh & Bridge No. 176 DN (Span 3x12.2m) in between station Belda-Bakhrabad (2nd Call). **Tender Value:** ₹ 125,56,63,525.18. **Earnest Money:** ₹ 2,51,13,300. **Tender Document Cost:** Nil. **Tender Closing Date, Time:** 17.07.2026 at 11.30 hrs. **Period of Completion:** 24 (Twenty-four) months. Interested Tenderers may visit website www.ireps.gov.in for full details/description of the tenders and to know the status of this tender so as to submit their bids online. Physical/manual tender for this work will not be accepted. (PR-289)

CENTRAL RAILWAY

CORRIGENDUM-1

Tender No. CR-BB-TELE-2026-53, Corrigendum-1 is been issued for tender no CR-BB-TELE-2026-53. **Tender Closing date is extended up to 01.07.2026 15.00 Hrs.** Details can be viewed on Website at www.ireps.gov.in Rest all other terms and conditions remain the same. **This tender complies with Public Procurement Policy Order 2017/ dated 15.06.2017**

It is forbidden to cross the railway gate in closed position

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER NOTICE

E-Tender notice no.: TL-AC-CRW-HRT-LHB-RMPU-3, Date: 05.06.2026

For and on behalf of President of India, Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut invites open e-tender for the following works as detailed:-

1. Name of work with its location: Overhauling and Repairing of Roof Mount Package Unit of LHBAC coaches (Qty. 1440 RMPU i.e 720 coach) at Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut for 03 Years. **2. Approx. cost of the work: Rs. 15,44,54,232.28/-** (Rupees Fifteen Crore Forty-Four Lakh Fifty-Four Thousand Two Hundred Thirty-Two And Paise Twenty-Eight only/-). **3. Cost of Tender Form:** Nil. **4. Bid Security to be deposited:** Rs. 30,89,100.00/- (Rupees Thirty Lakh Eighty-Nine Thousand One Hundred only/-). **5. Date & Time for submission of tender and opening of Tender:** The tender have to be submitted online on <https://www.ireps.gov.in> website upto 12.00 noon on 26.06.2026 and will be opened on the same day at 12:30 hrs., **6. Website particulars, Notice board location where complete details of tender can be seen and address of the office from where the tender form can be purchased etc:** Detailed tender notice, eligibility criteria & tender documents can be seen from the CRIS website: <https://www.ireps.gov.in> & full details of notice can be seen on notice board in the office of Chief Workshop Manager, Administrative Building, Carriage Repair Workshop, Harnaut, Nalanda, Bihar-803110. All corrigendum will be uploaded on website if required.

Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer
Carriage Repair Workshop/Harnaut
PR/0367/CRW-HRT/CRW/T/26-27/52

MSME TECHNOLOGY CENTRE
Ministry of Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises GOVT. OF INDIA
A1/1 Industrial Area, Ferozabad 203003, www.cdgindia.net

AI & CHATGPT TRAINING
AI Tools & Chat GPT

Course Duration (ONLINE) 2 Days **Date: 13 & 14 June 2026** **Time: 9:00 PM to 8:30 PM**

Course Content: AI Tools & Chat GPT, Modern prompting technique (R-C-O-P), Generative engine optimization basics for your website, Visual storytelling, Data driven marketing, Its advantages and limitations, Tips for writing effective Chat GPT prompts, Mastering social media content creation with chat GPT, Creating Epic YouTube content with Chat GPT, How to use chat GPT for keyword research, Creating Email marketing framework, Using Chat GPT for engaging Instagram reels, Using AIDA framework for advertising, Using chat GPT ethically, More Topics

Training is useful for Jobs, Professionals & Business

Fees : Rs.3,540/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)

Coordinator: 9818676612, 9818528498, 9686564246
Government of India certificate will be awarded

Ministry of Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises
MSME - TECHNOLOGY DEVELOPMENT CENTRE (CDG)
An Autonomous body under Ministry of MSME, Govt of India
A1/1 Industrial Area, Ferozabad 203003, www.cdgindia.net

2 DAYS GOVT. CERTIFICATE

NEW LABOUR CODES
(WITH CENTRAL RULES & LATEST UPDATES)

Course Duration (ONLINE) 2 Days **Date: 13 & 14 June 2026** **Time: 05:00 PM to 8:30 PM**

Course Content: Introduction to Labour Codes, Code on Wages, 2019, Industrial Relations Code, 2020, Occupational Safety, Health & Working Conditions Code, 2020, Code on Social Security, 2020, Compliance & Legal Risk Management, ESG, Labour Rights & Labour Codes, Practical HR & Payroll Workshop, Implementation Roadmap, More

Training is useful for Jobs, Professionals & Education

Fees : Rs.3,540/- (Study material in soft copy shall be provided)

FREE PAYMENT ONLY IN MSME GOVT. CREDIT ACCOUNT

Coordinator: 3603769600, 9953920498, 8168984069
Government of India certificate will be awarded

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE
(Mechanical Department)

The Divisional Railway Manager (Mechanical)/ E.C. Railway/Samastipur and on behalf of the President of India invites Open E-Tender under single packet system from experienced and financially capable tenderers for the following works in E-Tendering mode of IREPS web portal of Indian Railways :-

SI. No.: 1, Tender Notice No: M-TC-Mech-D Laundry-2026 dated 04.06.2026. Name of Work: Supply, Installation and commissioning of Departmental Mechanized Laundry of 01-ton capacity per shift of 8 hrs. (in kit) for JYG, Supply, Installation and commissioning of Departmental Mechanized Laundry of 01-ton capacity per shift of 8 hrs. (in kit) for SHC and Supply, Installation and commissioning of Departmental Mechanized Laundry of 01-ton capacity per shift of 8 hrs. (in kit) for SPJ, Tender Value (in Rs.): 519000.00, Completion period of the work: 09 Months

1. Receiving date and time for E-Tender mode on IREPS web portal: 25.06.2026 upto 15.00 hours.

2. Opening Date & time for e-Tender: 25.06.2026, 15.30 Hrs.

3. Web site particulars where complete details of tender document can be seen on Website: www.ireps.gov.in.

AME (TS & EnHM) E.C.R/Samastipur

PR/0365/SPJ/ENHM/T/26-27/44

CENTRAL RAILWAY

VARIOUS WORK

Open Tender Notice No. LCF/DR/OHE/ 506/2026/01, Dated 05.06.2026. Deputy Chief Electrical Engineer (Const.), Dadar, 4th Floor, Construction Office, Opposite to Platform No. 7 of Western Railway, Dadar (West) Mumbai - 400 028 on behalf of the President of India invites open tenders online through website from reputed contractors for the following work.

Name of work : Left over work of Design, supply of materials, modification, erection, removal of infringements, testing & commissioning of 25KV AC OHE in connection with Asangaon-Khardi Section of Kalyan Kasara 3rd Line in Mumbai Division of Central Railway. **Approx. cost:** Total Cost of work ₹ 19,31,38,433/- (Rupees Nineteen Crore Thirty-One Lakh Thirty-Eight Thousand Four Hundred & Thirty-Three Only). **Earnest Money :** ₹ 38,62,800/- (Rupees Thirty-Eight Lakh Sixty-Two Thousand Eight Hundred only) or as guided by the website www.ireps.gov.in

Completion period: 06 (Six) months including monsoon. **Cost of Tender Forms:** NIL. Validity of Offer : 90 (Ninety) days. **Website:** Tender Notice & Tender document can be accessed from Website www.ireps.gov.in **Date & Time of submission:** on 30.06.2026 up to 15.00 hours. **Date & Time of tender opening:** on 30.06.2026 after 15.00 hours. **Note:** Prospective tenderers are advised that before tendering their offers electronically, they should refer to the CRIS website www.ireps.gov.in for tender details regarding terms & conditions, eligibility criteria, mode of submission of cost of EMD & Tendered document etc.

It is forbidden to cross the railway gate in closed position

THE HINDU PRESENTS SCHOOL BUZZ
A Newspaper exclusively curated for School Students

AWARENESS PROGRAMME ON SAFETY AND WELL-BEING

TRS Global Public School CBSE, Arakkonam, organised an awareness programme on anti-ragging, drug abuse and road safety for their students. Principal Mrs. K. Kavitha welcomed the gathering and highlighted the importance of creating a safe, disciplined and responsible school environment. The programme was graced by Mr. R. Subramanyan, Chairman, Pro-Judge Circle Legal Services Committee Centre, Arakkonam, who spoke on legal awareness and the consequences of ragging and substance abuse. Mr. Yuvaraj, Selvi Amina and Mr. M. Gokul Mithun Kumar addressed students on law, personal responsibility and road safety. The session was coordinated by Mrs. R. Priya, Tamil Teacher, who also proposed the vote of thanks.

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT TRAINING FOR TEACHERS

Maharishi Vidya Mandir Higher Secondary School, Tiruvannamalai, conducted a 25-hour Professional Development Training Programme for teachers under the guidance of Brahmachari Girish Chandra Varma, Founder Chairman of the Maharishi Vidya Mandir School Group. The programme focused on NEP 2020, teachers' well-being, professional skill enhancement and the application of Artificial Intelligence in education. Principal Mrs. R. Anitha Ram inaugurated the programme and conducted sessions on NEP 2020 and 21st-century skills. Dr. Kavitha Thyagarajan served as the resource person, training teachers on the new curriculum framework, competency-based learning and Bloom's Taxonomy. Around 60 teachers participated and received certificates.

For Subscription related queries, please contact Subramaniam P: Handphone: +91 98408 98088 | Email: subramaniam.p@thehindu.co.in

Metro Railway, Kolkata

Tender Notice for e-tendering is invited by Principal Chief Engineer, Metro Railway for the following work: Name of work: Zonal Contract for up-keepment of structures including overhead/elevated structures & underground structures, sheds, staff quarters, repair & replacement of pipe line, fire hydrants, water supply arrangements, sanitary & drainage arrangements in elevated structures (via-duct), RTS Box including all service buildings, sheds, staff quarters at Dumdum & Noapara Car Depot Complex including Belghoria Station (via link line) upto and including Dakshineswar Station of Metro Railway from km (-) 105.07 (KDSW incl.) to km 110.4 (Dumdum incl.), Kolkata; **Approx Cost of Work: ₹ 3,11,47,550.81, Earnest Money : ₹ 63,20,000.00, Completion Period: Twenty Four (24) Months, Date and Time of Closing: 30.06.2026 at 12:00 Hrs.** The Tender Document and other details can be obtained from the website www.ireps.gov.in Amendments/Corrigendum, if any, would be hosted only on the website.

Abridged e-Tender Notice No.: Civil-2582-2026 (Open)

Follow us at: t.me/metrorailwaykol t.me/metrorailkolkata

CORRIGENDUM NOTICE

Tender No. : BDU-Consultant-04-2025 Dated: 26-05-2026

Closing Date : 16-06-2026

Name of Work: Engagement of Consultant for comprehensive market study to enhance freight, parcel traffic business over NFR, identification of feasible new Gati Shakti cargo Terminals, new Rly freight/parcel terminals, new Warehouses or Godowns and augmentation of existing facilities for increasing Rail coefficient.

In reference to the above floated tender, the following amendment is hereby issued to the Tender Document:

Page No.	Section/ Reference	Existing Provision	Revised Provision/ To be read as
23	Note : Point No. V	V. Key Personnel includes minimum 14 (Fourteen) personnel required for this assignment as proposed under point no. (12.1) of this under heading of team composition & qualification.	V. Key Personnel includes minimum 14 (Fourteen) personnel required for this assignment as proposed under point no. (IX)(f) of this under heading of team composition & qualification.

Note: All other terms and conditions of the original tender document and any previously issued corrigenda shall remain unchanged.

Full tender document along with all terms and conditions can be viewed in <https://www.ireps.gov.in>

Chief Commercial Manager/FM
Maligaon, Guwahati-11

NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY
"SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE"

INDIAN RAILWAYS

PATIALA LOCOMOTIVE WORKS
PATIALA - 147003
Tel.: 2396000, 2396001, Fax No. : 91-0175-2306413

Notice inviting Electronic Tenders

On behalf of President of India Principal Chief Materials Manager/PLW/Patiala invites tenders in electronic form for following items:

e-Tender Notice No. 10 ET/2026-27

SN Tender No.	Description	Qty.	Tender closing date
1	21261067 Complete Cubicle F	219 Sets	01.07.2026*
2	21261135 Primary Current Sensor Box	160 Sets	23.06.2026
3	22261237 Leather Bellow with Mounting Arrangement	109 Sets	20.07.2026*
4	20261124 All Steel Lock Nut	159 Sets	01.07.2026*
5	21261123 Led Based Twin Beam Head Light	266 Sets	13.07.2026**
6	21261107 Microprocessor Based Electronic speed Indicating	104 Sets	21.07.2026*
7	21261077 Axle Box Complete without bearing	181 Sets	06.07.2026*
8	21261131 Led Based Electrical signal exchange system	526 Sets	22.06.2026
9	02261065 Sleeve Bearing	37 Nos	29.06.2026
10	21261094 PANTOGRAPH MOUNTING INSULATOR. ROOF LINE INSULATOR	486 Nos. 682 Nos.	26.06 2026*

TENDER HAS BEEN PUBLISHED ON IREPSAS ON 05/06/2026.

Tender closing Time 15:00 Hrs

Item marked with * is reserved for procurement from CLW approved sources. Item marked with ** is reserved for procurement from RDSO approved sources.

The prospective tenderers are advised to visit the website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> or <http://www.plw.indianrailways.gov.in> for detailed description of items & other terms and conditions of tender document. Please note that Tenderers can submit their quotations only through <http://www.ireps.gov.in>.

CORRIGENDUM TO e-TENDER NOTICE NO. 07 ET/2026-27

Closing date of Tender No.21261046 may be read as 25.06.2026. 1952/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE



Unity in diversity

INDIA bloc is more divided than before, allowing the BJP to push ahead

Twenty-three Opposition parties aligned under the banner of the INDIA bloc met in the national capital on Monday, against the backdrop of countrywide concerns related to economic distress, inflation and the chaos in the educational sector. Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, Leader of the Opposition (Lok Sabha) Rahul Gandhi, Sonia Gandhi, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav and the Trinamool Congress (TMC)'s Mamata Banerjee were among those who attended. Mr. Kharge announced five key decisions at the close of the meeting. The bloc resolved to write to the Chief Justice of India over concerns of electoral fraud and vote manipulation; demanded the immediate resignation of the Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan; called upon the central government to convene an all-party meeting to address the deepening economic crisis, farm distress and price rise; agreed to hold coordination meetings every two months, with the next one scheduled in Hyderabad in August; and committed to daily parliamentary coordination during sessions. The decisions signal a collective resolve to press the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on governance failures, particularly in the areas of economy and education, and to hold together an institutional framework for Opposition coordination.

The meeting followed evident fissures within the alliance that surfaced during the recent round of Assembly elections, in which constituent parties found themselves on opposing sides in several States. The shadow of the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK)'s departure loomed large. The DMK, once the INDIA bloc's most powerful southern anchor, stayed away entirely, having formally announced its boycott on June 4. The decision stemmed from a bitter fallout following the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, where the Congress cut its long-standing ties with the DMK to join a coalition government led by actor-turned-politician C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam. The DMK's future plans *vis-à-vis* the Opposition remain subject to considerable speculation. The Aam Aadmi Party too chose to stay away, having formally declared that it was no longer part of the bloc. The TMC, yet another large constituent, is facing severe internal challenges after its electoral defeat in Bengal. The Left-Congress relationship too has soured, with both sides trading accusations of being ineffective in combatting communalism, or even worse, complicit in it. Taken together, these absences and tensions expose how fragile the coalition can be in a moment of crisis, and how deep the structural conflicts of interest run among its partners. That said, there appears to be a broad, if reluctant, consensus among the participants on two overriding imperatives: that checkmating the BJP remains essential to the political survival of each constituent party and to the health of Indian democracy, and that the Congress, for all its deficiencies and contradictions, remains the unavoidable pivot of any credible national, secular and progressive formation in India.

Strategic afterthought

The government must be transparent with the Nicobar project

For a project so often invoked as a matter of national security strategy, the ballooning Great Nicobar Island development, now estimated to be at ₹91,000 crore, rests on a remarkably thin strategic record. The Centre has long cited the "strategic" character of its centrepiece – a transshipment port at Galathea Bay – to withhold information on its environmental clearances. Yet, the Public Investment Board (PIB), a Finance Ministry body, found in August 2024 that the port "lacked strategic objectives". That label arrived only afterwards, from the Ministry of Defence and seems less like a founding rationale and more of an afterthought, retrofitted to a balance sheet. Both the PIB and the Public-Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (PPPAC) cleared the proposal, yet the PPPAC refused ₹12,230 crore in Viability Gap Funding, telling the Ports Ministry to find the money within its own budget – an unusual rebuke for a venture sold as nationally vital. If the port cannot stand on commercial returns, and if its real purpose is military, the case for a commercial transshipment hub dissolves.

Great Nicobar sits at the southern tip of the Andaman and Nicobar archipelago, wrapped in tropical rainforest and ringed by reefs of rare ecological value. The project – port, international airport, power plant and township – would clear vast tracts of that forest, much of it primary, and disturb the nesting beaches of the leatherback turtle and the habitat of the endemic Nicobar megapode. Scientists who have studied the island warn that the loss would be irreversible, and that no afforestation elsewhere can replace what is felled here. The island's indigenous inhabitants have objections of their own, running alongside the ecological ones but not reducible to them. Tribal councils have said that consent was secured without full disclosure, and asked that ancestral land and the resettlement promised after the 2004 tsunami not be overridden by the project. Their criticism is not a refusal of all development. The quarrel is with scale, secrecy and sequence – a project conceived at a magnitude the island cannot absorb. The remedy is transparency. The Centre should release the High-Powered Committee report in full, account openly for the true cost to the public exchequer, and weigh it against an environmental loss that the exchequer can never reimburse. A project of this scale owes the country at least that much.

The judgment of the Supreme Court of India, delivered on May 27, 2026, on the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, has thrown up many disturbing questions about the powers, the role and the conduct of the Election Commission of India (ECI) in the context of the exercise of its powers in the preparation and revision of electoral rolls.

Although this case is related to the operationalisation of the SIR in Bihar, the issues dealt with by the Court and its findings have far-reaching implications for the right of Indian citizens to be included in electoral rolls. In its 124-page judgment, the Court dealt with all the important points raised by the petitioners against the SIR but refused to concede even a single one of them. On the other hand, the Court accepted all the arguments made by the ECI and further elucidated them.

Revisiting electoral roll revision

When the SIR was begun in Bihar just a few months before the Assembly election in Bihar, in 2025, serious reservations were expressed about the advisability of undertaking such a comprehensive and intensive revision of the electoral rolls in such haste. Apart from the inexplicably compressed timeline for completing the intensive revision of the electoral rolls, serious questions were raised about the statutory backing for such an exercise. There have been a number of articles in this daily highlighting the ECI's deviations from statutory provisions in the implementation of the SIR. So, in light of the Court's judgment upholding the ECI's actions and methods, it is useful to revisit the statutory and constitutional provisions governing electoral roll preparation and revision and assess the judgment accordingly.

Article 325 of the Constitution declares that there shall be one general electoral roll for every territorial constituency in the country and that no person shall be ineligible for inclusion in such a roll solely on the grounds of religion, race, caste, sex, or any of them. Article 326 says that the elections to the Lok Sabha and the Assemblies shall be on the basis of adult suffrage – which means every citizen who is 18 years and above is entitled to be registered as a voter at any such election. The other condition for inclusion in the roll is that he should not be disqualified under the Constitution or any law. Article 327 empowers Parliament to make laws for dealing with all aspects of elections including the preparation of electoral rolls. Article 324 confers the power to prepare the rolls and conduct the elections on the ECI. Preparation of electoral rolls which



P.D.T. Achary

Former Secretary General, Lok Sabha

The top court's verdict raises constitutional concerns and casts a shadow over past electoral rolls

includes revision is governed by the Representation of the People (RP) Act, 1950 and the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Section 21 of the RP Act deals with preparation and revision of the electoral rolls. Sections 21(2) and (3) which contained the framework of revision say in (a)(i)/(ii), electoral roll shall be revised before each general election to the Lok Sabha or the Assembly and before each by-election, (b) the roll shall be revised in any year if directed by the ECI; and Section 21(3) says that the ECI may do a special revision of the roll for any constituency or part of a constituency at any time after recording the reasons for such revision. Rule 25 of the Registration of Electors Rules says that the revision of the rolls under Section 21 (2) of the Act before the general election or by-election can be summary or intensive, which clearly implies that such revision just before the general election can be only summary considering the elaborate scheme of an intensive revision under the rules.

The framework

The question, then, is: under which category of revision does the SIR fall? The Court says that it is traceable to Section 21(3) which deals with a special revision in any constituency or a part of a constituency. But the clause does not permit an intensive revision but only a special revision. SIR is a special and intensive revision of the rolls. Intensive revision according to Rule 25 is done only under Section 21(2) and not 21(3) of the Act as the judgment claims. A careful reading of Sections 21(2) and (3) of the RP Act 1950 and Rule 25 of the Registration of Electors Rules 1960 would reveal that an intensive revision of the roll in a State can be undertaken only when the general election or by-election is not due. It is obvious that an intensive revision is not contemplated by the law when the elections are due because of the comprehensive nature of the revision which requires a much longer time to complete.

Now, as regards the special revision under Section 21(3), it is actually meant to be done in a constituency or a part of a constituency and not the whole State or the country. The claim made in the judgment that "any constituency" means all constituencies does not square with the context. The word "any" may mean 'all' in some contexts whereas it would mean 'single' in some other context. The words "or a part of constituency" following "any constituency" make it clear that the special revision is meant to be done only in a constituency or part of it. When intensive revision is clearly provided in Section 21(2) there is no need to provide the same in Section 21(3). Special revision may become

The Oman CEPA, a new gateway for India's exports

India and Oman share one of the oldest trading relationships, with commercial and maritime links dating back thousands of years. From the movement of spices, textiles and frankincense to enduring people-to-people ties, trade has long been a cornerstone of this partnership. The India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA), which came into force on June 1, 2026, reaffirms and strengthens this historic relationship by providing a modern framework to deepen trade, investment and economic cooperation for the future.

India is amongst the top suppliers for Oman and bilateral trade has grown from \$8.94 billion in FY2023-24 to \$11.18 billion in FY2025-26, reflecting the growing complementarities between the two economies.

An expansion of India's trade ties

The CEPA comes at a time when India is actively diversifying its trade partnerships and integrating more deeply with global value chains. Following agreements with the United Arab Emirates, Australia, the European Free Trade Association, the United Kingdom, New Zealand and the European Union, the Oman CEPA further strengthens India's presence in a region that is central to its energy security, trade and strategic interests.

The CEPA offers significant opportunities for Indian exporters. Oman has offered duty-free access on 98.08% of its tariff lines, covering 99.38% of India's exports by value. Before the agreement, only 15.33% of India's exports entered Oman at zero duty under the Most Favoured Nation regime. The CEPA, therefore, provides an immediate competitiveness boost across a broad range of sectors. In textiles and apparel, India already commands a 43% share of Oman's woven apparel imports and 31% of knitted apparel imports. The removal of the existing 5% tariff will strengthen the competitiveness of Indian manufacturers against China, which is the other dominant supplier in this market. In the case of chemicals, India already supplies nearly 39% of Oman's inorganic chemical imports, making it



Anant Goenka

President, The Federation of Indian Chambers of Commerce and Industry (FICCI)

The agreement boosts exports, services, investment and professional mobility

one of the leading players in the market. Tariff free access will only amplify this further.

Likewise, engineering goods will also benefit. Oman imports over \$3.7 billion worth of mechanical machinery and \$3.3 billion worth of automobiles annually, where India's market share is only 5% and 2%, respectively. Preferential market access under the CEPA can help Indian exports of engineering goods expand significantly and deepen their presence in Oman's infrastructure, construction and industrial sectors.

In pharmaceuticals, where India holds around 10% market share, the agreement's value lies not in tariff reductions but in regulatory facilitation. Products approved by leading international regulators will benefit from fast-tracked approvals, reducing compliance costs and accelerating market entry. As Oman's pharmaceutical market continues to expand, Indian companies will be well-positioned to capture a larger share. Duty-free access for products such as meat, eggs, honey, butter and processed foods will further strengthen India's already strong position. At the same time, sensitive sectors such as dairy, cereals, edible oils and several agricultural commodities have been kept outside tariff concessions, ensuring that domestic producers remain protected.

Streamlining procedures

Significant trade facilitation measures have been introduced. Oman will accept certificates issued by India's Export Inspection Council (EIC), eliminating duplicative testing and inspections, while also recognising India's organic (NPOP) and halal certification systems. There are dedicated sanitary and phytosanitary (SPS) and technical barriers to trade (TBT) provisions, which will enhance regulatory transparency and cooperation, and streamlined customs clearance, including fast-track processing for perishables, which will reduce costs and improve export efficiency.

Another forward-looking aspect of the CEPA is its strong focus on services and professional mobility. Bilateral services trade stood at \$863

necessary in some constituencies because of, say, the large-scale influx of people into that area from a neighbouring area. Special revision is done in a manner fixed by the ECI whereas intensive revision under Section 21(2) needs to be done as per the prescribed procedure.

The analysis above would show that the entire SIR exercise is being done under a wrong provision of law. In the States of Bihar, Tamil Nadu, Kerala and West Bengal, the SIR was done a few months before the Assembly election. Under Section 21(2)(a) read with Rules 25 only a summary revision was possible before the Assembly election. But the ECI went ahead with the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in clear deviation from the scheme of the law, resulting in the deletion of millions of voters from the electoral rolls without providing them any effective redress.

The issue of citizenship

The judgment grants great freedom to the ECI in the matter of determining the documents to prove citizenship. The crucial point is whether the ECI can determine what documents are required to prove citizenship. This is a function to be performed by the Home Ministry as it administers the law on citizenship. The ECI's role is to verify citizen-related documents. What actually happened was that the ECI announced a list of documents and asked the voters to produce them. The ECI was simply usurping the role of the Union Home Ministry. It is extremely surprising that during the hearing the Supreme Court did not ask the Union Home Ministry to file an affidavit containing the list of documents required to prove citizenship. The Court has now conceded the ECI's authority to determine the question of citizenship for the purpose of inclusion in or exclusion from the electoral rolls, while leaving the larger question of citizenship to the competent authority, namely the Ministry of Home Affairs. The Ministry of Home Affairs will now have to decide the cases of millions of Indian citizens who will never be able to vote in their lifetime and who will face numerous disabilities arising from the denial of citizenship, albeit on a tentative basis.

The Court has hitherto applauded the work done all these years by the ECI since its establishment. But the SIR judgment speaks about the "cumulative inaccuracies in the voters list" and the "structural deficiencies that pervaded the entire roll" in the past. It is a damning indictment of the preparation and the revision of electoral rolls done by the ECI in the past. The judgment need not have gone to such an extent in order to justify the SIR of 2025.

million in 2024, with India enjoying a surplus of nearly \$447 million. Yet, India's share in Oman's global services imports remains just over 5%, indicating substantial untapped potential.

Oman has undertaken binding commitments covering professionals in sectors such as accounting, engineering, information technology, health care, education and consulting. Oman also raises the quotas for intra-corporate transferees, facilitating greater mobility of Indian professionals and specialists. Provisions relating to AYUSH and traditional medicine further create opportunities for Indian health care and wellness services in the Gulf.

Strategic location advantage

Beyond trade statistics, the CEPA has a larger strategic significance. Oman occupies a unique position at the crossroads of the Gulf, the Indian Ocean and East Africa. Its ports at Sohar, Duqm and Salalah are emerging as major logistics and industrial hubs. For Indian businesses, Oman can serve not only as a destination market but also as a gateway to the wider Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) region and East African economies.

The India-Oman CEPA once again demonstrates the evolution of India's trade policy from tariff negotiations to comprehensive economic partnerships encompassing goods, services, investment, mobility and regulatory cooperation. Its benefits will extend from textile clusters in Tamil Nadu and the gems and jewellery industry in Gujarat to engineering hubs in Maharashtra and Punjab, and from pharmaceutical manufacturers in Telangana to seafood exporters in Andhra Pradesh and Kerala.

The real test will now lie in implementation and utilisation. If businesses actively leverage the opportunities created by the agreement, the CEPA can significantly expand India's export footprint, strengthen economic integration with the Gulf, and support the country's broader ambition of becoming a globally competitive manufacturing and services powerhouse. For India, the agreement opens not only the Omani market but also a broader gateway to the Gulf and beyond.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Nepal's claim

The reports, "Not seeking mediation on border dispute: Nepal FM" (June 8), "No role for third parties in bilateral matters between India, Nepal: Centre" (June 3), and "Nepal PM sparks row, says his country has encroached upon Indian territory" (June 1), are interesting points of contrast. But the candid

admission by Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah, of Nepal's encroachment on Indian territory, should shock New Delhi. Did India have any inkling of such an encroachment? The Ministry of External Affairs should take cognisance of the issue. In all fairness, the Nepal Prime Minister should volunteer to return the encroached territory to

India as a gesture of goodwill.

C.V. Aravind,
Bengaluru

The difference now

Today's youth engage with public issues differently from previous generations. The recent Gen Z mobilisation over educational policies and systemic failures has shown

how a discussion or idea on social media can rapidly evolve into large-scale protests. This growing participation reflects a generation that values transparency and accountability in governance and seeks a greater voice in shaping its future. Constructive engagement with their concerns would be far more

effective than dismissing their voices.

Navaneeth S. Kumar,
Kollam, Kerala

Border crossings

When I visited the Petrapole-Benapole border in West Bengal in 2002, it was striking to see hundreds of people carrying headloads of rice across the border under the nose of

the BSF. In these circumstances, one wonders whether the 'concerns' over the formation of a High-Level Committee on Demographic Change amount to intellectual overreaction.

K. Chellappan,
Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

The trust deficit in India-Bangladesh ties

More than hundred days have passed since the Tarique Rahman government took charge in Bangladesh. However, contrary to early expectations from his leadership, India-Bangladesh relations have remained more or less the same as in the difficult months of the interim government.

Actions, not rhetoric
India reached out twice before Mr. Rahman became the Bangladesh Prime Minister. The first outreach was by External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar who visited Dhaka on December 31, 2025 to condole the passing of Mr. Rahman's mother, former Prime Minister Khaleda Zia. The second time was through Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri, who carried Prime Minister Narendra Modi's invitation letter, and Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla who on February 17 participated in the swearing-in ceremony of Mr. Rahman. But sources in the ruling Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) say such gestures in themselves are insufficient. An influential segment within the BNP feel that as a goodwill gesture towards the new government, India should have reversed some of the retributory steps that it had taken during the interim government's rule under Muhammad Yunus. These steps included the restarting of transhipments for goods from Bangladesh, full restoration of visa services including business and medical visas, and stopping the restrictive market access for Bangladeshi goods. None of these measures have been implemented so far, as per Dhaka. They argue that, by not reversing these decisions, India has not delivered any advance incentives to Mr. Rahman who will have to engage with the Jamaat-e-Islami and several anti-India student outfits before normalising ties with India. On its part, the BNP's veteran leaders have tried to smoothen the relationship by creating greater public acceptability of the position



Kallol Bhattacharjee

Bangladeshi diplomats have pointed out that Dhaka expected less rhetoric on illegal immigration, and more focus on issues such as the renewal of the 1996 Ganga Water Treaty

that the presence of the deposed Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina in India will not hold ties back, a departure from the hardline stance that the interim government had taken. Here also, Dhaka feels that such attempts have not found appreciation from the Indian side. As proof they refer to the aggressive use of 'illegal immigration' in official communication from Delhi following the victory of the Bharatiya Janata Party in West Bengal and Assam. Bangladeshi diplomats have pointed out that Dhaka expected less rhetoric on sensitive issues such as illegal immigration, and more focus on issues such as visa restoration and the renewal of the 1996 Ganga Water Treaty. Dhaka had sent Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman to Delhi on April 7-8 for a brief visit, to test the waters, where he met National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and Mr. Jaishankar. However, the election campaign in Assam and West Bengal around Bangladesh-related issues and a flurry of interviews by exiled PM Sheikh Hasina have displayed that Mr. Rahman's BNP, despite winning a landslide majority in Bangladesh, has not managed to impress India. While a senior diplomat in Dhaka said that Bangladesh was assured that the language around State elections would not reflect New Delhi's foreign policy, the Ministry of External Affairs' strident position on illegal immigration have generated 'a sense of betrayal' in Dhaka's secretariat. According to reports, Mr. Rahman, sensing that the window for restoration of ties with India is not opening as per expectations, is in the final stages of considering visits to Malaysia and China that are likely to take place in the last week of June. **Bangladesh's dilemma** This turn to China however cannot hide the fact that it is incumbent on Bangladesh, as much as it is on India, to repair bilateral ties.

Bangladesh's ties with India remain broken because of the 2024 uprising and the subsequent interim rule whereas its ties with China, the U.S. and other players have prospered since August 2024. Further, a pragmatic assessment shows that without steady assurance from India on the main river Padma (Ganga), Bangladesh's other plans are not expected to proceed smoothly beyond 2026. River affairs expert Ainun Nishat has stated that a delay in the renewal of the 30-year-old Ganga treaty will put the Ganges-Kobadak irrigation project in a challenging situation affecting vast portions of western and central Bangladesh. The lack of predictable water supply will affect the upcoming sowing seasons, hurting Bangladesh's economy that is already dealing with the crippling effects of the energy crisis because of the U.S.-Israel war on Iran. The compounded effect of these disruptive forces will increase pressure on the Tarique Rahman government that is already under criticism for its inept handling of the worst measles outbreak in the country that has claimed the lives of at least 600 infants. Critics have targeted the government for its weak handling of the health crisis as well as the growing incidents of sexual violence, which is a symptom of the breakdown of law and order in the country that is yet to make a recovery since the protests of August 2024. Rivals, including Sheikh Hasina's Awami League that are mobilising on the ground despite a ban, will be strengthened if Mr. Rahman fails to renew the Ganga river agreement with Delhi before the deadline of December 31, 2026. Such material factors on the ground call for pragmatism in both the capitals as the challenges will soon overwhelm Bangladesh, reverting it to instability, which again is not in India's immediate or long-term interests.

kallol.b@thehindu.co.in

A boost for the Karnataka workforce

The notification on minimum wages is a step in the right direction

STATE OF PLAY

Mohan Mani

In May, the Karnataka government released the notification on minimum wages, equalising wages across 81 sectors of employment, with an average wage increase of 60% over existing levels. As per the notification, the minimum wage for unskilled workers will be ₹23,376 per month in Bengaluru, and ₹19,318 per month in small towns and rural areas. This difference of over ₹4,000 between wages in Bengaluru and the small towns is a reflection of the runaway inflation in metro cities. This move, which acknowledges the high cost of living in urban metros, is commendable. In media interviews, the Karnataka Labour Minister said the minimum wage revision was carried out as per the directions of the Supreme Court. This highlights an often ignored fact of the jurisprudence around minimum wage in India – that the method for minimum wage determination is elaborately laid out and uniformly applicable across the country. Despite such a formula, the wide variation in prevailing minimum wages across States reflects the power of employers, and the complicity of labour departments in keeping wages below what is statutorily mandated. Employers claim that higher wages drive up product costs and increase product demand thus fuelling inflation. However, reducing the wages of those at the lowest deciles of the Indian population in order to curtail their consumption cannot be the way to control inflation. Moreover, government statistics indicate that the consumption levels of



the average household are yet to reach pre-COVID levels. There are other mechanisms available to the Government to control inflation, including adjusting the GST structure to control product costs. Employers further claim that increasing wages will drive out industry. This is not necessarily true. The contribution of wages to total cost in most sectors is declining. Wages are not the only determinants of investment decisions. Several other factors such as infrastructure, economic climate, availability of skilled workforce, and industrial peace are equally important. The recent protests by garment and other factory workers in the National Capital Region region and in Uttar Pradesh for higher wages were a stark reminder of workers' poverty and their desperation. It highlighted the importance of decent wages to ensure industrial peace. **Missing aspects** However, there remain important lacunae in the notification. First, it leaves out four important sectors: garment work, *beedi* rolling, *agarbathi* making and plantation work. All four sectors employ a large number of workers, with the majority being women. With the implementation of this notification, the wages of the workers in these four sectors would become around half the wages of the workers at a

comparable skill level in the other 81 sectors covered by the notification. *Beedi* rolling, which is primarily home-based work, highlights the inter-generational perils of poorly paid employment. Children share the same space as their mothers, who are rolling *beedis*, which often results in them getting pulled into helping their mothers, restricting their ability to break out of the poverty trap. A decent minimum wage linked piece rate for *beedi* rolling could increase the options for these children. Another issue is regarding the Variable Dearness Allowance (VDA). The VDA is meant to safeguard real wages against inflation for the period between two wage fixations, mandated to happen once every five years. The points-based wage neutralisation system in Karnataka unfortunately only protects fully real wages in the lowest unskilled categories. For the higher categories of semi-skilled and skilled workers, such protection is only partial. Further, with every wage revision, the old VDA formula becomes inadequate to protect real wages, and the points need to be revised. There have been union led court cases in the past for VDA revision along with wage revisions. The present notification should also address this lacuna. The minimum wage notification is still a positive step, holding out potential for equitable growth in the State. It can also serve as an example for other States. It highlights an alternative paradigm, important at this time of increasing wealth disparity – that profits without super-exploitation should be the route to the "ease of doing business". Mohan Mani is a Visiting Fellow, National Law School of India University, Bengaluru

DATA POINT



CHART 2: This shows the geographical spread. Hypothetically, a fan, wanting to watch at least one match in all 16 venues, should travel a minimum of 11,347 kms as the crow flies. This was only 70 kms in 2022, between five cities in Qatar

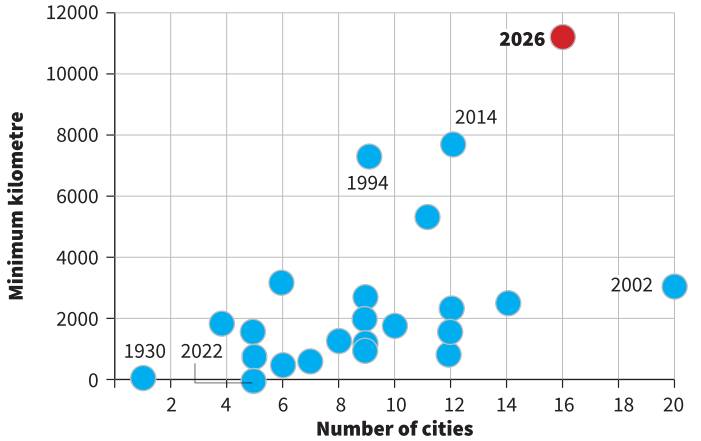


CHART 3: The event stands out for a few notorious reasons, including the sky-high ticket fares. This shows the price ranges as of June 8, 2026 6 p.m. IST

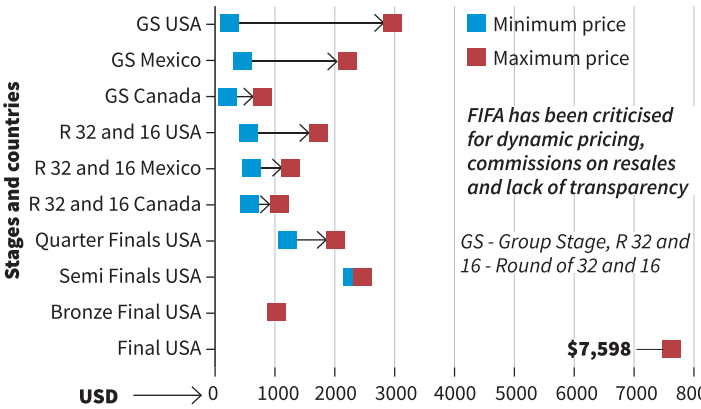
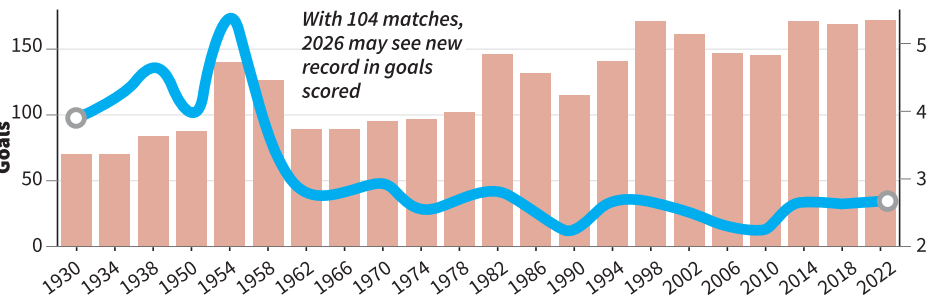


CHART 4: Though the number of goals have increased over the years, the average goals scored per match has plateaued around 2.6 in recent years



A World Cup like no other

MAP 1: The tournament is hosted by three countries, the U.S., Canada and Mexico, which is a first. It is being held across 16 venues, which is the second-highest after the 2002 edition, when matches happened across 20 cities in South Korea and Japan



CHART 5: 2026 could see a competition between 37-year-old Messi, for whom this is likely to be the last World Cup, and 27-year-old Mbappe, to set a new record as the highest goal-scorer in a World Cup



CHART 6: The chart shows the highest, lowest and average rankings in the 12 groups of four members each. Shorter the line, the tighter the competition within the group

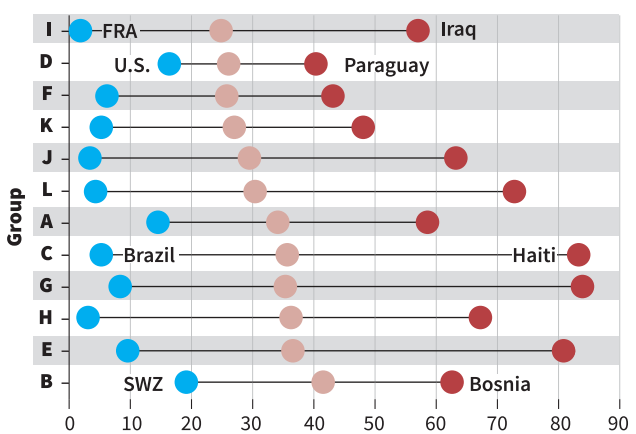
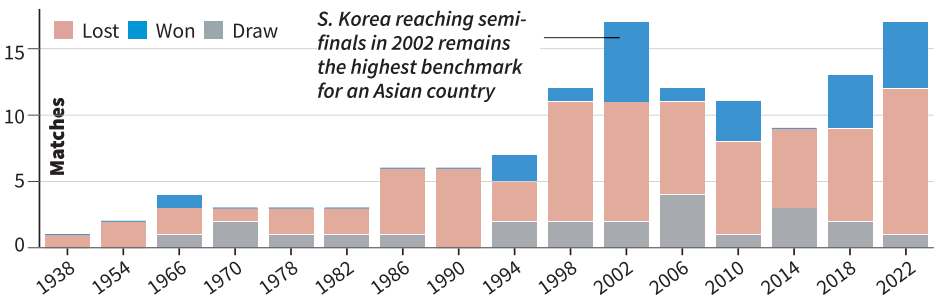


CHART 7: Eight from Asia — Japan, Iran, Jordan, South Korea, Uzbekistan, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and Iraq — are playing in 2026, the highest-ever. Asian countries recorded their highest wins in 2022 (11)



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO JUNE 9, 1976

ICF likely to produce tramcars

Madras, June 8: The Integral Coach factory is likely to manufacture tramcars for Calcutta Tramways. The factory authorities are now negotiating with the Tramway company, the details of producing 100 numbers of 2-car sets (200 trams). Each set will cost about Rs. seven lakhs. Disclosing this at a press conference here to-day, Mr. J. Mathan, General Manager, said that the ICF had extra capacity and hence was trying to branch out to a new line of production. At present, it was manufacturing 535 shells and 518 coaches out of a rate capacity of 700 in each. Even now, the factory was deploying its workers to repairs of wagons and coaches of the Indian Railways, as the zonal railways did not have adequate capacity for carrying out these repairs. The motors for the trams would be manufactured and supplied by the Bharat Heavy Electricals. Between 1968 and 1975, the ICF had supplied to many nations in Asia and Africa over 309 bogies and 266 coaches costing over Rs. 10 crores. An order for supply of 17 metre gauge coaches for East African Railways at a cost of Rs. 2.15 crore was expected to be completed by July.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO JUNE 9, 1926

Progress of monsoon

Simla, June 8: A feeble advance of the Arabian sea monsoon has given general rain in Malabar and Bombay Deccan. Bay monsoon is strengthening. The western disturbance has passed away. Rainfall has been nearly general in Lower Burma, Malabar, Bombay Deccan, Local in Assam, North Hyderabad while a few falls occurred in Upper Burma, Bengal, Bihar, East Rajaputana, East Central Provinces, South Hyderabad and South East Madras. Chief amounts are: — Mergui, Rangoon 3-4, Tavoy, Kyaukpyu 1, Maymo 1 and a half, Berhampore, Mymensingh 3-4, Udaipur 1-2, Jagdalpur 3, Cochin 2, Poona, Sholapur, Cuddalore 1-2, Kodaikanal 1 inch. Temperature is appreciably above normal in central parts of the country and North East of the Peninsula. Forecast of monsoon rainfall for 1926: — Monsoon rainfall is likely to be normal in the Peninsula and in north-east India but in some defect in north west India.

From Page One

20 Trinamool MPs plan to form a separate bloc

Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha member Sukhendu Sekhar Roy, who resigned from the party and the Upper House of Parliament, was also present at the meeting.

Among the 20 rebel MPs were Howrah MP Prasun Banerjee, Bankura MP Anup Chakraborty, Cooch Behar MP Jagadish Chandra Barma Basunia, Bolpur Lok Sabha MP Asit Kumar Mal, Birbhum MP Satabdi Roy, Jhargram MP Kalipada Sorren and Bardhaman Purba MP Sharmila Sarkar.

The meeting was held not far from the gathering at Constitution Club of India where Trinamool chairperson Mamata Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek Banerjee took part in the INDIA bloc meeting.

Later in the day, the West Bengal Chief Minister reached the residence of Trinamool MP Satabdi Roy in the national capital and held a meeting with about 10 MPs of the rebel camp.

Meanwhile, former Kolkata Mayor and Mamata Banerjee's close aide Firhad Hakim met Ritabrata Banerjee at the West Bengal Assembly. Mr. Hakim, a Trinamool Congress legislator, had recently quit as Mayor of Kolkata.

Weighing in on the political developments, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh posted on X: "The Union Minister of Environment, Forests, and Climate Change who looked after elections in West Bengal has spent the day poaching. This Minister's special job is to nab poachers and prevent poaching and not be one himself."

Eight killed in blast at Visakhapatnam plant

A 24x7 control room has been set up at the Collectorate (phone numbers 0891-2590100 and 2590102) to coordinate with officials and relatives of the victims.

The RINL is the corporate entity of the Visakhapatnam Steel Plant (VSP).

Speaking to *The Hindu*, the District Manager of 108 Ambulance Services M. Suresh stated that 10 ambulances were deployed to the site immediately following instructions from the District Medical and Health Officer (DMHO) and Collector. "We have shifted several victims with severe burns ranging from 40% to 90% while five ambulances remain stationed at the spot to assist rescue teams," Mr. Suresh said.

Heavy Smoke Hampers Rescue Operations

Earlier, dense smoke and towering flames had trapped several personnel inside the shop floor of the facility. Fire tenders and emergency rescue teams from both the steel plant and State departments rushed to the location and were working late into the night under hazardous conditions to douse the flames and rescue the stranded workers.

Police officials tracking the rescue operation noted that the molten metal was kept at an ultra-high temperature of nearly 1,600 degrees Celsius before it spilled, making immediate access to the core blast zone extremely difficult.

INDIA bloc to take SIR complaints to CJI

Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav cautioned that after the setbacks in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu, defeating the BJP in the Uttar Pradesh Assembly election early next year would be crucial.

While acknowledging the Congress's pan-India presence, he urged it to be "large-hearted" and allow dominant regional parties to take the lead wherever appropriate.

According to sources, he also flagged the earlier exit of Janata Dal (United) leader Nitish Kumar, suggesting that the outcome of the 2024 general election might have differed had he stayed.

RJD leader Tejashwi Yadav echoed the criticism, saying that despite warnings about possible cross-voting by Congress MLAs in the recent Rajya Sabha election in Bihar, no action had been taken.

CPI(M) leader John Brittas said Rahul Gandhi, as the face of the INDIA bloc, should have refrained from making unsubstantiated allegations against the Kerala government during the Assembly campaign.

Israel, Iran warn each other against escalation

Earlier, U.S. President Donald Trump demanded that Israel and Iran "immediately stop 'shooting'". The flurry of attacks drove oil prices up around 4% and threatened to wreck efforts towards a deal to end the war.

The semi-official Fars and Mehr news agencies said Israeli strikes hit a petrochemical factory in the city of Mahshahr. The Israeli military confirmed the strike on the plant, saying it targeted sites that produce materials for ballistic missiles. Israel said it also targeted truck-based missile launchers.

Israel said its strikes were in response to an Iranian missile attack. Tehran had warned on Sunday that it would retaliate after Israel struck Beirut's southern suburbs without warning.

24 Indian sailors rescued from ship attacked by U.S.

Marivex, sanctioned by the U.S. last December, had earlier carried Iranian oil to India; U.S. Central Command says the tanker violated the ongoing blockade by attempting to sail to an Iranian port

M. Kalyanaraman
Debayan Tewari
CHENNAI

Twenty-four Indian seafarers were rescued from tanker *Marivex*, a ship sanctioned by the U.S. for Iran links, off the south-eastern coast of Oman on Monday, after a U.S. missile strike.

The sailors sent distress messages to a Forward Seamen's Union of India (FSUI) office-bearer that the U.S. Navy had attacked the ship's engine room.

Audio messages from the seafarers to Manoj Yadav, general secretary of FSUI, received at 2 p.m. (India time) say: "This is Motor Tanker Marivex. Fire on board. Vessel is sinking. U.S. Navy attacked with missile our engine room. We have a hole at the bottom."

U.S. Central Command (Centcom) said in a statement that "U.S. forces disabled (attacked) an unladen oil tanker in the Gulf of Oman, June 8, after the vessel violated the ongoing blockade against Iran by attempting to sail to an Iranian port. An F/A-18 Super



Smoke rises from *Marivex*, off the coast of Oman, on Monday, after a suspected U.S. missile attack. FSUI

Hornet from USS Abraham Lincoln (CVN 72) fired a precision munition into the ship's engineering and steering spaces after the crew failed to comply with directions from U.S. forces. *Marivex* is no longer sailing to Iran."

The *Marivex* crew's distress message says that there was a U.S. warship nearby that was not helping, neither was there an immediate response from the Maritime Rescue Coordination Centre. Video clips sent to Mr. Yadav show a seafarer from the

ship pointing to a warship nearby. The audio messages say the lifeboats on one side of the ship were also hit in the attack and the other side lifeboats were not accessible due to a fire that had broken out.

Eventually, a rescue operation evacuated the 24 Indian seafarers, who had moved to the front-end of the ship since the back-end of the vessel was on fire, through helicopter.

The seafarers are now on the Masirah Island in Oman, and safe, said Mr. Yadav. "All of them are in a

India expanded its nuclear arsenal in 2025, says SIPRI

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

India is estimated to have modestly expanded its nuclear arsenal in 2025 and continued developing new nuclear delivery systems, according to the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) Yearbook 2026 released on Monday.

The report estimated that India's nuclear stockpile had increased to around 190 warheads by early 2026. The country had around 180 such warheads in 2025.

SIPRI noted that New Delhi's ongoing nuclear modernisation programme is increasingly focused on developing longer-range weapons capable of reaching targets across China, while continuing to address security concerns arising from its long-standing rivalry with Pakistan.

The annual assessment of global armaments, disarmament and international security also highlighted the May 2025 India-Pakistan military confrontation, describing

The report estimates India's military expenditure at \$92.1 billion, an increase of 8.9% from last year

Operation Sindoor as an "unusually severe military crisis" between the two nuclear-armed neighbours.

According to SIPRI, India carried out strikes during the conflict against Pakistani air and missile bases that were likely to have nuclear-related roles. However, the institute observed that both countries took measures to prevent further escalation despite heightened tensions.

The report further noted that India and Pakistan integrated cyberoperations into active military conflict for the first time during the crisis, underscoring the evolving nature of modern warfare and deterrence in South Asia.

Beyond the nuclear domain, India retained its position as the world's fifth-largest military spender in 2025. SIPRI estimated India's military expenditure

at \$92.1 billion, an increase of 8.9% over the previous year. The country ranked behind only the United States, China, Russia and Germany in defence spending.

India also remained the world's second-largest importer of major arms during the 2021-25 period, accounting for 8.2% of global arms imports. SIPRI identified Ukraine, India, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, and Pakistan as the five largest arms importers, collectively accounting for 35% of global imports during the period.

Modernising arsenals

The report said all nine nuclear-armed states – the United States, Russia, the United Kingdom, France, China, India, Pakistan, North Korea, and Israel – continued to modernise their arsenals and increasingly relied on nuclear weapons as instruments of national power. Globally, the nine countries possessed an estimated 12,187 nuclear warheads at the start of 2026, of which around 9,745 were held in military stockpiles for potential use.

state of shock and most of them have lost their phones. They are expected to reach India in two days," he said.

'Tanker was empty'

A statement from the Centre said a "fire incident was reported today aboard the vessel *MT MARIVEX* at approximately 13:30 hours off the coast of Oman."

Earlier, at a news briefing, Opesh Kumar Sharma, director at the Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways, declined to comment on the cause of the fire. "The vessel has 24 Indian seafarers, all are reported to be safe," he said. He added the tanker was empty and located away from the Strait of Hormuz.

Marivex is a ship sanctioned by the U.S. government last December, as per shipping database Equasis.

Marivex was one of the few ships that exited the Strait of Hormuz on April 9 just when the ceasefire was declared. It had then carried crude oil from Bandar Abbas in Iran to Mangalore. *Marivex* has been operating in the "conflict zone", said Mr. Yadav.

'India, China should see each other as partners, not rivals'

Press Trust of India
BEIJING

China and India should stick to the "right strategic perception" that they are not rivals but cooperative partners and opportunities for each other's development, not threats, a top Chinese official said on Monday.

Foreign Ministry spokesperson Lin Jian made the remarks at a media briefing here in response to a question on Russian President Vladimir Putin's comments on Sino-India relations and Moscow's efforts to maintain close ties with both countries.

The China-India border situation is at the moment generally stable and the two sides have smooth communication, Mr. Lin said.

Beijing has been reiterating for a while that India and China should not regard each other as rivals but cooperative partners. Mr. Lin's response adds "right strategic perception" to that oft-repeated narrative.

"The two sides need to



President Droupadi Murmu confers Kirti Chakra on Group Captain Prasanth Balakrishnan Nair during a ceremony in New Delhi. PTI

President presents gallantry awards to security personnel

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

President Droupadi Murmu on Monday conferred seven Kirti Chakras, including two posthumously, on personnel of the armed forces for displaying raw courage, unparalleled bravery and total disregard for personal safety in the line of duty.

Air Commodore Prasanth Balakrishnan Nair, an Indian Air Force pilot and Gaganyatri, was also among the recipients of the Kirti Chakra, India's second-highest peacetime gallantry award. Ms. Murmu also conferred 15 Vir Chakras, including three posthumously, and 29 Shaurya Chakras, includ-

ing one posthumously, on the personnel of the defence forces, Central Armed Police Forces and State and Union Territory police forces during Phase I of the Defence Investiture Ceremony hosted at Rashtrapati Bhavan.

Lt. Commander Dilna K. and Lt. Commander Roopa A. of the Navy were among the Shaurya Chakra recipients. The President presented the award to them for their bravery and devotion to duty in '*Navika Sagar Parikrama 2'*.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi also attended the ceremony. In a post on X, he said, "We are proud of their extraordinary courage, commitment and selfless service to the nation."

Rajnath Singh reviews HAL projects; Tejas delivery delay under scrutiny

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Monday reviewed the progress of major ongoing projects of Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd. (HAL) at a high-level meeting held at Kartavya Bhavan, with delays in the delivery of Light Combat Aircraft (LCA) Tejas MkIA featuring prominently in the discussions.

During the meeting, Mr. Singh directed the Chairman and Managing Director of HAL, K. Ravi, to strictly adhere to delivery schedules for all defence projects and execute programmes critical to the armed forces' modernisation plans on time.

According to senior officials, the Defence Ministry is also examining the possibility of imposing penalties on HAL for delays in the delivery of Tejas MkIA fighter aircraft to the Indian Air Force. Officials said six GE F404 engines required for the programme had already arrived in India, while nearly 18 Tejas MkIA airframes were ready. With engine supplies beginning to stabilise, authorities are hopeful that HAL will be able to deliver the aircraft by the end of the year.

The Tejas MkIA deliveries have faced repeated delays due to supply chain disruptions and delays in engine deliveries from the U.S. To accelerate production and meet future requirements, HAL has set up established three dedicated production lines – two in Bengaluru and one in Nashik.

The Tejas MkIA programme remains a key pillar of the IAF's fighter fleet modernisation effort. The Air Force has contracted 83 aircraft under a deal worth over ₹48,000 crore. The government has also cleared the procurement of an additional 97 aircraft, significantly expanding the programme's scale.

'Nicobar project will enhance maritime security'

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

Under the Great Nicobar Island Development Project, India plans to invest around ₹13,000 crore to build a dual-use airport and runway for both civilian and Navy operations, said a senior official with the Ministry of Defence on Monday.

According to sources in the Ministry, the project, expected to be completed within five years, will be jointly funded by the Ministry along with the Ministry of Civil Aviation. The government views the initiative as a strategic investment aimed at strengthening maritime security, boosting regional connec-

tivity and enhancing India's presence in the Indo-Pacific region.

Four components

Elaborating about the project, the official said the project comprises four major components – an International Container Transshipment Port (ICTP), a joint-user greenfield airport and Naval Air Station, a modern township, and a power plant. Together, these projects are expected to transform Great Nicobar into a key maritime and economic hub while enhancing India's defence capabilities in the strategically significant Indian Ocean Region (IOR).

Located just 40 km from the Six Degree Channel,



The project comprises a port, airport, and power plant. AFP

one of the world's busiest sea trade routes connecting the Gulf of Aden and the Malacca Strait, Great Nicobar occupies a critical position along global shipping lanes. Government officials said the project

would reduce India's dependence on foreign transshipment ports and strengthen its ability to monitor and secure vital Sea Lanes of Communication.

The proposed greenfield airport, approved by the Union Cabinet and to be operated by the Indian Navy, is expected to significantly improve maritime domain awareness, logistics support, and rapid deployment capabilities. The airport is also expected to promote tourism, officials said. It is understood that five sites, including INS Baaz at Campbell Bay, were assessed before Galathea Bay was selected for the airport. Technical constraints, limited expansion possibilities, and environ-

mental concerns reportedly made the expansion of INS Baaz unviable.

Extensive studies

Addressing concerns over environmental impact and tribal rights, officials said the project has undergone extensive environmental assessments involving institutions such as the Zoological Survey of India, Wildlife Institute of India and the Salim Ali Centre for Ornithology and Natural History. Of the island's total area, only 166.1 square kilometres have been earmarked for development, while more than 81% will continue to remain under forests, biosphere reserves, national parks and tribal conservation zones.

IN BRIEF

KYIV

Ukraine recaptures more than 600 square km in 2026: military chief



Ukrainian forces have recaptured more than 600 square kilometres of territory so far this year, Ukraine's top military commander Oleksandr Syrskiy said on Monday, the latest sign of a changing tide after years of slow but relentless Russian gains. In May alone, Ukraine recaptured 100 sq. km more of territory than it lost. REUTERS

PORT LOUIS

Mauritius rejects reported move by Trump to buy Chagos Islands



Mauritius said on Monday that it had not received any proposal from the [Donald] Trump administration on the Chagos Islands, after the *Telegraph* reported that the White House was planning to buy the islands. "Mauritius's position remains unchanged: its sovereignty over the Chagos is non-negotiable," it said. REUTERS

HERAT

Afghan Taliban detain women for alleged violation of clothing rules



Afghan residents in the city of Herat witnessed multiple women detained by the Taliban government's morality police, in a crackdown over clothing which has drawn criticism from the United Nations. The UN mission in Afghanistan said on Sunday that the arrests and detentions raise "serious human rights concerns." AFP

LONDON

U.K. PM set to ban 'harmful' social media for teens under-16: report



Tech giants operating in Britain must stop children from circulating nude images on their phones or be forced to do so by law, Prime Minister Keir Starmer said on Monday. The announcement comes as the *Times* reported that the Prime Minister is also mulling a ban on some social media platforms for those aged under 16. REUTERS

Houthis claim missile attack, declare 'total ban' on Israeli ships in Red Sea

Yemen-based Iran-aligned group launches air attack on Israel, says Israel-affiliated ships would again become a target in the Red Sea; the escalation comes as the Strait of Hormuz remains blockaded by Iran due to the war in West Asia with the U.S.

Agence France-Presse
SANAA

Iran-aligned Houthi rebels in Yemen announced a missile attack on Israel on Monday and declared a ban on Israeli shipping in the Red Sea, raising the spectre of a return to major disruption on the key route.

The Houthis' attack came as Israel and Iran traded fire on Monday, putting the ceasefire under renewed strain and threatening hopes for a peace deal.

The Houthis made a similar threat and targeted cargo ships in the vital sea-way during the Israel-Hamas war, forcing many companies into a lengthy detour around the tip of



War fallout: Two men examine a rocket half-buried in the ground near the West Bank city of Jericho on Monday. AFP

southern Africa. The assaults upended shipping in the Red Sea, through which about \$1 trillion of goods passed each year before the war.

Their threat comes as the Strait of Hormuz, the gateway to the Gulf sea and

its energy exporters, remains blockaded by Iran as a result of the war in West Asia with the U.S. and Israel.

'Legitimate targets'
"We declare a complete and total ban on Israeli

maritime navigation in the Red Sea," said a statement from the Houthis' armed forces. "We consider all enemy movements to be legitimate military targets for our armed forces from the moment this statement is issued."

The statement from Brigadier General Yahya Saree was broadcast on the Houthis' al-Masirah satellite news channel.

The Houthis, who joined the war in support of Iran in March, had not announced a missile attack on Israel since a fragile ceasefire began on April 8.

The Houthis have fired missiles at Israel during the Israel-Hamas war and later, but haven't been fully involved in the Iran war.

They said they "launched a missile barrage targeting sensitive Israeli enemy targets", claiming the strikes "achieved their objectives with precision".

The Israeli military earlier wrote on Telegram that it "has identified the launch of a missile from Yemen toward Israeli territory, aerial defence systems are operating to intercept the threat".

An Israeli military official said two missiles were fired by the Houthis since Sunday evening.

The Houthis and Lebanon-based Hezbollah form part of the "Axis of Resistance" grouping of pro-Iran forces opposed to Israel and the United States.

Major quake off Philippines kills at least 35, many missing

Agence France-Presse
MANILA

A 7.8-magnitude earthquake in the southern Philippines on Monday killed at least 35 people, according to provincial authorities, after toppling buildings and sparking tsunami warnings across the region.

National disaster authorities said at least a dozen people were still missing, while 134 had sustained injuries.

Authorities urged people in affected coastal regions to move to higher ground after the offshore quake hit south of General Santos, a city of about 720,000, where the death toll stood at 12, according to a local command centre.

A series of powerful aftershocks rocked the area from about two hours after the first quake, according



Rubbled remains: A damaged building seen in General Santos, Philippines, following a magnitude 7.8 quake on Monday. AP

to the U.S. Geological Survey, with the largest measuring magnitude 6.5.

Rene Punzalan, disaster chief for hard-hit Sarangani province, said 14 people had died in Glan municipality alone when a landslide buried their homes.

Mr. Punzalan said that more than 2,000 people evacuated due to a morning tsunami warning were now awaiting a green light to return to their homes.

The Pacific Tsunami Warning Center issued a tsunami alert for the Philippines, Indonesia, Palau, Taiwan and Papua New Guinea. But by mid-afternoon, the notices were cancelled.

President Ferdinand Marcos Jr. ordered an immediate disaster response. "The national government is moving and we will not leave anyone behind," Mr. Marcos said in a statement.

Lebanon was struck close to 3,500 times since truce: Minister

Reuters
BEIRUT

Israel has carried out nearly 3,500 air strikes on Lebanon and hundreds of controlled explosions since the U.S.-brokered ceasefire came into effect on April 17, Lebanon's Defence Minister, Michel Menassa, said on Monday.

During a Cabinet meeting, Mr. Menassa said that from April 17 to June 7, Israel had carried out 3,491 air strikes, 407 controlled demolitions and six "raz-

ing" operations, or demolitions - which have left some entire villages in the southernmost strip of Lebanon entirely flattened.

Already, more than 1 million people have been displaced by Israel's strikes and evacuation warnings across Lebanon since the war erupted on March 2.

While Israel has largely halted air strikes on Beirut and its suburbs, the truce has failed to stop the fighting in southern Lebanon between Israel and Iran-aligned group Hezbollah.

Xi and Kim express hopes for greater ties between China and North Korea

Associated Press
SEOUL

Chinese President Xi Jinping and North Korean leader Kim Jong-un underscored their commitment to deepen cooperation in a closely watched summit on Monday, as Mr. Xi made a rare visit to Pyongyang in a likely attempt to reassert Beijing's unique influence over its socialist neighbour.

It's Mr. Xi's first visit to North Korea in seven years. Earlier on Monday, he was given a lavish welcome upon arrival at Pyongyang's international air-



Rare visit: Chinese President Xi Jinping and North Korean leader Kim Jong-un at a welcome ceremony in Pyongyang on Monday. AP

port. He and his wife Peng Liyuan were greeted by Mr. Kim and his wife Ri Sol Ju.

Mr. Xi later arrived at Pyongyang's main square,

where a military honour guard and thousands of people staged a welcoming ceremony.

In a summit later in the

day, Mr. Xi expressed China's willingness to expand cooperation in a wide range of areas including trade, agriculture, construction and technology, China's state broadcaster CCTV said in an online report.

Mr. Kim said Mr. Xi's visit "clearly demonstrates how unbreakable" the North Korean-China relationship is, CCTV said. It cited Mr. Kim as saying that consolidating a new era of friendship between the two countries is the "unchanging strategic choice" of North Korea.

Trump's \$100,000 fee for H-1B visa fee is unlawful, court rules

Reuters
BOSTON

A federal judge on Monday struck down a \$100,000 fee that U.S. President Donald Trump imposed on new H-1B visas for highly skilled foreign workers, concluding that it constituted an unlawful tax that Congress never authorised.

U.S. District Judge Leo Sorokin in Boston issued the ruling in a lawsuit filed by 20 Democratic State Attorneys General challeng-

ing a fee Mr. Trump announced in September that raised the cost of obtaining H-1B visas.

The H-1B program offers 65,000 visas annually, with another 20,000 visas for workers with advanced degrees, approved for three to six years. Employers seeking a visa for a foreign worker before Mr. Trump's proclamation paid about \$2,000 to \$5,000 in fees. The increase in fees has discouraged H-1B visa requests, according to court filings.

Sport

England has an exciting bunch... to be the best, you have to beat the best

In a World Cup, it is always match by match, and we are concentrating on the three group-stage matches against Croatia, Ghana and Panama. A pulsating battle awaits

INTERVIEW

Harry Kane

The influential England striker, Harry Kane, will look to end the country's 60-year World Cup drought as he leads the side for the third time. Excerpts:

Your third World Cup as England captain...

Obviously, it is a great honour for me to lead my country for the third time in a World Cup. When my career as a professional footballer took off, I had a dream to represent the Three Lions in a World Cup. Now, it will be my third as captain; I did not

even dream about it! In all these editions, we tried our best to win it (title) but could not. This year, too, the ambition is the same. It is difficult to predict where we will finish, but the will is there. England always plays to win.

With 48 teams, winning the World Cup seems to be more difficult...?

Winning the World Cup has always been difficult, no questions! Yes, the winner this time will be playing one more match in the knockout stage. That does make it more difficult. But it is good to have more nations in the final phase. When there are more teams, there are more challenges. If you need to be the best, you have to

beat the best teams.

In 2018, England lost in the semifinals. It is the closest you have come to the trophy. You won the golden boot, too...

Yes, it was heartbreak for all of us. Losing to Croatia in extra time, our dream ended with Mario Mandzukic scoring late (109th minute) at the Luzhniki Stadium. However, we learned from our mistakes and played well in the following tournaments. We reached two Euro finals (in 2021 and 2024). Although we didn't win, reaching the final of a continental tournament is commendable.

How disappointing was the penalty miss against France in 2022?

Well, at that time, I felt that it was the lowest point of my career. We were in the World Cup quarterfinals and 1-2 behind when the opportunity knocked at our door. I failed to convert from the spot. It, however, made me stronger. I had to change my penalty-taking technique a little and I did not miss one in the next 30 or so. I continue to take penalties for my teams - club and country. It has helped me mentally.

England will be playing under a new coach in Thomas Tuchel...

He was in Bayern Munich and was one of the reasons behind me joining the German club. We had a lovely understanding, and he used me differently there.

That continued even after he left the job at Bayern and became our national team coach. It's exciting to have him as the head coach of our side.

With the new coach and some new faces, can England reach the summit?

The goal is to be there, but it will be difficult. World Cup is the most challenging task for the players, managers and teams. We have some exciting new talents under an able coach who knows how to use us tactically.

England is placed in a tough group (Croatia, Ghana and Panama)...

That is true. We start

against Croatia, the finalist in Russia 2018 and semifinalist in Qatar 2022. Our semifinal defeat (2018) will again be discussed before the match. Luka Modric and his team will be keen to follow the same route. Ghana is strong while Panama is ready to surprise the world. We expect a pulsating group battle.

The knockouts will be tougher even if you top the group...

In a World Cup, it is always match by match. So, we are concentrating on these three group-stage matches. Each team is a challenge. So, there is no point in overthinking. Let us do the job at hand first. (Professional Management Group).



Priceless gem: Kane's goal-scoring form augurs well for England as it prepares to face a tricky group-stage test. GETTY IMAGES

STATUS QUO

No extra emphasis on Pant to change his game, says Kotak



R.V. MOORTHY

India's batting coach Sitanshu Kotak said on Monday there is no additional emphasis on Rishabh Pant to alter his game. "I don't think Pant alone has to play according to the situation. Everyone should play freely, but when the team requires something in red-ball cricket, every player should adapt accordingly," said Kotak.

COMFORTABLE WIN

Shreyanka, Radha spin India past Windies in T20 WC warm-up tie



X@BCCIWOMEN

Shreyanka Patil and Radha Yadav shone as India scored a 26-run win over the West Indies in a T20 World Cup warm-up fixture at Cardiff on Monday. **The scores:** India 179/8 in 20 overs (Shafali 29, Smriti 39, Yastika 36, Bharti 56 n.o.) bt West Indies 153/8 in 20 overs (Dottin 49, Campbelle 25, Radha 3/25, Shreyanka 4/36). **Toss:** WI.

IN AND OUT

Brazil midfielder Ederson replaces injured Wesley in the WC squad



FIFA

The Brazilian football federation announced on Sunday that injured full-back Wesley will be replaced in the World Cup squad by midfielder Ederson. Wesley suffered a thigh injury in Saturday's 2-1 friendly win over Egypt. Atalanta's 26-year-old Ederson made the last of his three international appearances in March 2025.

RUN SNAPPED

Marschall ends Duplantis' 40-meet winning streak in pole vault



REUTERS

Swedish pole vaulter Armand Duplantis fell to his first loss after 40 consecutive victories since 2023 at his home Diamond League event in Stockholm on Sunday. Duplantis cleared 5.80m but failed twice at 6 and once at 6.05. Australia's Kurtis Marschall (*in pic*) won with a vault of 5.90. It was Duplantis' first outdoor event of the year.

Manav and Washington bowl India to its biggest victory

The debutant claims a six-for in the first essay; the offie scalps four while Kuldeep strikes thrice as the Afghans get bundled out for 112 after following on, crashing to a defeat well inside three days

AFGHANISTAN IN INDIA

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

The one-off Test against Afghanistan was India's first at home since 2010 without either the now-retired R. Ashwin or the rested Ravindra Jadeja. Much like Ashwin and Jadeja at their vintage best in the subcontinent, left-arm spinner Manav Suthar and off-spinner Washington Sundar dovetailed nicely to propel the host to victory by an innings and 300 runs inside three days at the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium on Monday. It is India's biggest win by an innings in Test history.

Notwithstanding the caveat that the Afghans lack skill and experience in the five-day format, India will take a lot of heart from Manav's match haul of seven wickets on debut. The 23-year-old left-arm spinner returned exemplary figures of 22-10-33-6 in the first essay, becoming the seventh Indian to take a five-for in his debut innings.

In the second dig, Washington came to the fore with four for 36 while left-arm wrist-spinner Kuldeep Yadav chipped in with three scalps.

Replying to India's mammoth 564 for eight declared, Afghanistan, which was 113 for five overnight, was shot out for 152 and 112. The one-sided contest came to a close shortly after the tea interval, with the visitor's implosion entailing the fall of seven wickets for just 25 runs in its second innings (Sharafuddin Ashraf was absent hurt).

Having conceded a first-innings deficit of 412, Hashmatullah Shahidi & Co.



Spin twins: Manav and Washington accounted for 12 wickets as India crushed Afghanistan in the one-off Test. R.V. MOORTHY

were forced to follow on. They had a more robust start second time around as Sediqullah Atal stitched together a 42-run opening stand with Abdul Malik. Sediqullah's keenness to take on the Indian spinners was evident.

But once Mohammed Siraj pinned Malik plumb in front in the 14th over, India had a foot in the door.

As the afternoon wore on, the Afghan batters couldn't strike the right balance between attack and defence. Rahmanullah Gurbaz, Rahmat Shah and Sediqullah succumbed to rash shots just before tea.

In Afghanistan's first in-

nings, Manav ran through the lower-order. Adding to his three victims on Sunday, the youngster induced a faint edge from Sharafuddin Ashraf.

In his next over, the tweaker punched the air in delight as he castled Rahmat around his legs for his five-for. Just three balls later, he trapped Mohammad Saleem leg-before.

A large chunk of Manav's deliveries homed in on the good-length area. Through his spells, he conveyed the impression of a bowler acutely aware of the demands of the classical version. It points to a bright future.

SCOREBOARD

INDIA — 1ST INNINGS
564 for eight decl. in 127 overs
AFGHANISTAN — 1ST INNINGS
Abdul Malik c Siraj b Manav 16 (18b, 3x4), Sediqullah Atal b Prasidh 17 (27b, 3x4), Rahmanullah Gurbaz c Sai Sudharsan b Manav 12 (40b, 1x6), Rahmat Shah b Manav 60 (135b, 9x4, 1x6), Hashmatullah Shahidi lbw b Prasidh 20 (48b, 4x4), Afsar Zazai c & b Manav 3 (26b), Azmatullah Omarzai b Prasidh 0 (10b), Sharafuddin Ashraf c Pant b Manav 11 (32b, 2x4), Nangeyalia Kharote (not out) 4 (12b), Mohammad Saleem lbw b Manav 0 (3b), Ziaur Rahman c Pant b Washington 6 (3b, 1x6); Extras (nb-2, w-1): 3; Total (in 58.4 overs): 152.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-28 (Malik, 5.4 overs), 2-40 (Sediqullah, 8.4), 3-62 (Gurbaz, 19.2), 4-98 (Shahidi, 32.2), 5-113 (Afsar, 39.5), 6-118 (Omarzai, 44.2), 7-142 (Ashraf, 55.1), 8-143 (Rahmat, 57.2), 9-143 (Saleem, 57.5).

INDIA BOWLING
Siraj 9-2-29-0, Prasidh 11-2-37-3, Manav 22-10-33-6, Kuldeep 10-1-32-0, Washington 6-4-1-21-1.
AFGHANISTAN — 2ND INNINGS
Atal c Prasidh b Washington 42 (80b, 5x4, 1x6), Malik lbw b Siraj 8 (40b), Gurbaz c Prasidh b Kuldeep 24 (24b, 3x4, 1x6), Rahmat c Manav b Washington 13 (16b, 1x6), Shahidi c Gill b Washington 5 (10b, 1x4), Afsar lbw b Manav 8 (19b, 1x4), Omarzai c Kuldeep b Washington 4 (5b), Kharote c Manav b Kuldeep 6 (11b, 1x6), Ziaur (not out) 0 (11b), Saleem c Sai Sudharsan b Kuldeep 0 (1b), Ashraf (absent hurt); Extras (nb-2): 2; Total (in 35.5 overs): 112.

FALL OF WICKETS
1-42 (Malik, 13.1), 2-74 (Gurbaz, 19.1), 3-87 (Rahmat, 22.6), 4-93 (Shahidi, 26.3), 5-98 (Sediqullah, 28.6), 6-106 (Afsar, 31.5), 7-106 (Omarzai, 32.1), 8-112 (Kharote, 35.4), 9-112 (Saleem, 35.5).

INDIA BOWLING
Manav 10-2-29-1, Prasidh 3-0-6-0, Kuldeep 7-5-1-30-3, Siraj 4-1-11-1, Washington 11-4-36-4.

PoM: Manav.
India won by an innings and 300 runs.

Next match: First ODI: June 13, Dharamshala, 1.30 p.m.

Test cricket is a game of patience: Manav

Vivek Krishnan
NEW CHANDIGARH

The Indian cricket ecosystem has had its eye on Manav Suthar for a few years. In conversations, many would speak glowingly of the 23-year-old's rhythmic action, flight, bounce and the revolutions imparted, all of which allowed the left-arm spinner to extract considerable turn even on flatter surfaces.

There was irrefutable evidence of all his virtues over the past three days as Manav stole the show in his debut Test against Afghanistan at the Maharaja Yadavindra Singh Stadium. Admittedly, the batters at the other end weren't out of the top drawer, but on a deck that was far from be-



In elite company: Manav castled Rahmat to become the seventh Indian to register a five-for in his debut innings. R.V. MOORTHY

ing a dustbowl, Manav turned heads just by the frequency with which he spun the ball past the right-handers.

The fruits of his hard work were figures of six for 33 in 22 overs in the first innings, facilitating his addition to an elite list of Indian

bowlers with five-wicket hauls on debut.

Afterwards, Manav, adjudged the Player-of-the-Match, couldn't hide his delight at the proceedings in New Chandigarh. "It is an unreal feeling. My dream from the beginning was to play Test cricket for

India. At the start, I wanted to see how the pitch was playing. So, I backed the stock delivery. Then, I used subtle variations. Test cricket is a game of patience, so just bowl with patience," he said at the presentation.

Back in Sri Ganganagar, a city in Rajasthan that is located near the border with Pakistan, Manav's father echoed his son's fondness for the classical version. "I always believed that Manav would play Test cricket for India first. White-ball cricket can come later," Jagdish Suthar, a retired school teacher who had attended the first day's play, told *The Hindu*.

Now, it is up to Manav to make this the first of many appearances.

Iran arrives amidst a tumultuous lead-up; France and Spain bring their star power

FIFA WC COUNTDOWN

N. Sudarshan

Placed in a tough Group I, France, Senegal and Norway will have to bring their A-game to the FIFA World Cup. Belgium (G), Spain and Uruguay (H) have a relatively easier start to the campaign.

Group G (Belgium, Iran, Egypt and New Zealand)
Belgium's golden generation finished third in 2018. In 2026, that gold has lost its sheen.

The likes of Kevin De Bruyne, Thibaut Courtois, Romelu Lukaku and Axel Witsel are still around, but the famed backline comprising Toby Alderweireld, Vincent Kompany, Thomas Vermaelen and Jan Vertonghen no longer exists.

Coach Rudi Garcia will thus be pinning his hopes on his attack, which also has the speedy Manchester City winger Jeremy Doku.

There are, however, doubts over Lukaku's preparedness, with Belgium's all-time top-scorer (90 goals) playing just an hour of football all season for Napoli.

But the strength of the group is such that Belgium is the favourite. Iran, at No. 21, and Egypt, at No. 29, are both not up to scratch.

Iran has featured in each of the last three World Cups, but has exited in the group stage. Currently, the country is in the middle of a military stand-off with the United States, something that seriously threatened its participation.

And because of safety concerns, Iran will be based in Mexico, and travel long distances to Los Angeles and Seattle to play. Supreme tenacity will be the need of the hour.

Egypt, at least on paper, seems slightly better because it has Mohamed Salah. The world stage is one place where he is yet to excel, having played just two games in Egypt's group-stage exit in the 2018 showpiece.

The 33-year-old will also be eager to reiterate his footballing worth after a not-so-pleasant exit from Liverpool.

Surprisingly, Egypt, a seven-time Africa Cup of Nations champion, has never won a match at the World Cup. Will the largely turgid football it plays, with the only goal-scoring route through Salah, help break the duck?

There is a chance that this approach may work against New Zealand, the lowest-ranked side at the tournament (No. 85). For that, Nottingham Forest's Chris Wood, scorer of 45 goals for the Kiwis, should be shut down.

Interestingly, the New Zealand football team is called 'All Whites', contrary to the unofficial national colour black. White is about peace. But sport is war minus the shooting.



Linchpins: Mbappe will be keen to regain France's World Cup crown. De Bruyne's Belgium comes with an ageing squad while Yamal will be Spain's bow and arrow. AFP, REUTERS & AP



Best finish: Belgium: Third place (2018); Iran: Group stage (1978, 1998, 2006, 2014, 2018, 2022); Egypt: Group stage (1934, 1990, 2018); New Zealand: Group stage (1982, 2010).

Group H (Spain, Uruguay, Saudi Arabia and Cape Verde)

Ever since Spain won its maiden World Cup in 2010, it hasn't gone past the round of 16. In 2026, it can't afford a similar fate.

Ranked second in the world, Spain arrives in North America with a first-rate side, despite not having a single player from Real Madrid.

The 2024 European champion's trump card will be Barcelona star Lamine Yamal, already the metronome for both club and country.

And in Nico Williams and Mikel Oyarzabal, the 18-year-old winger will be supplemented well. Yamal and Williams sustained hamstring injuries recently but are expected to be fit.

In midfield, there is an embarrassment of riches, with Pedri, Gavi, Martin Zubimendi, Rodri and Fabian Ruiz all in the roster.

Three world-class goalkeepers in Unai Simon, David Raya and Joan Garcia, and the calming presence of Barcelona defender Eric Garcia make the Luis de la Fuente-coached team well-rounded.

Competing with Spain for the top spot – however improbable it looks – will be Uruguay, the two-time Cup winner.

But the Marcelo Bielsa-marshalled outfit, despite being powered by Real Madrid midfielder Federico Valverde, no longer has that cutting edge quality, especially without strikers Luis Suarez (omitted) and Edinson Cavani (retired).

For success, it needs to summon the spirits that helped beat Brazil and Argentina in 2023, and finish third at the 2024 Copa

America. Saudi Arabia, the third-best side in the group, famously beat Argentina 2-1 at Qatar 2022. But it no longer has the coach who masterminded that heist – Herve Renard.

Georgios Donis from Greece was appointed only two months ago, and he has his task cut out if his wards are to match the round-of-16 effort from 1994 (also in the United States).

Cape Verde, an archipelago off Africa's west coast with a population as low as six lakh, is the fourth member.

It's the third-smallest nation ever at a World Cup, and a majority of the squad is foreign-born as a result of significant outward migration before the country gained independence from Portugal in 1975.

Best finish: Spain: Champion (1998, 2010); Uruguay: Champion (1930, 1950); Saudi Arabia: Round of 16 (1994); Cape Verde: Debut.

Group I (France, Senegal, Norway and Iraq)

If Brazil and Argentina are football's eternal favourites, France is its new-found royalty. In the last seven editions, the European nation has won the World Cup twice, finished runner-up twice and made another quarterfinal.

The central figure here is coach Didier Deschamps, who won the World Cup in 1998 as a player and has been France's manager since July 2012. The North American sojourn will be his swansong, and he will be eager to part on a high.

Kylian Mbappe is his main man, with Ballon d'Or winner Ousmane Dembele and Bayern Munich winger Michael Olise forming the support cast. That players such as Desire Doue and Bradley Barcola – both from Paris Saint

Germain – are likely to start from the bench says a lot about *Les Blues'* strength.

But in the 14 years Deschamps has been in charge, France has been criticised for playing with its handbrake on. If the side can marry its defensive solidity – only four goals conceded in the qualifying – with its fearsome attack, opponents will have a torrid time.

Senegal would want to remind France that it has not always played out that way. The African nation upset the then defending champion in 2002 en route a quarterfinal finish. And in 2026, it remains strong, powered by former Liverpool star Sadio Mane.

Interestingly, Senegal won the Africa Cup of Nations in January only to be stripped of the title after some of its players left the field during the final protesting a penalty awarded to Morocco. The case awaits adjudication at the Court of Arbitration for Sport. An authoritative on-field effort will not hurt.

Norway is the underdog in this group despite having Manchester City's Erling Haaland and Arsenal's Martin Odegaard. The Nordic country is returning to the World stage for the first time since 1998. Can it leave an indelible mark?

For Iraq, qualification itself should count as success. The war-torn nation was the last to punch its ticket, beating Bolivia in an away Inter-Confederation Playoff in March after travelling 12 hours by road and 17 hours by air. Whatever it does in North America will be a bonus.

Best finish: France: Champion (1998, 2018); Senegal: Quarterfinal (2002); Norway: Round of 16 (1998); Iraq: Group stage (1986).

** The 1934 World Cup was a 16-team knockout tournament.*

Over the next two weeks in Dambulla, up in the north of Sri Lanka, the 15-year-old will be squarely in the limelight, and in the crosshairs of the Sri Lanka and Afghanistan bowlers

The Sooryavanshi mania

GETTY IMAGES

R. Kaushik

One August afternoon in 2004, August 16 to be precise, a familiar name popped up on the cell phone screen, indicating an incoming call from a recently retired and highly celebrated Indian fast bowler. The said individual was trying his hand at commentary, and was in Nairobi for a triangular one-day series involving host nation Kenya, and the ‘A’ teams of India and Pakistan. “Are you watching the match?” the old friend asked, excitedly, breathlessly. Under the mistaken and optimistic impression that he was seeking feedback on his commentary, one mumbled something under the breath when he piped up, “Turn on the TV. Watch this guy, he is something else.” “This guy” was a muscular, long-haired, earthy 23-year-old who had played for Bihar in 1999, and then for Jharkhand from the time the new State was carved out in November 2000. Five years of senior representative cricket had identified him as one for the future, though how much in the immediate future, one wasn’t sure. Then came the tri-series in Nairobi, where the right-hander batted at No. 3, and produced two bruising hundreds against Pakistan ‘A’, the first of them a day after India’s Independence Day. Batting with a freedom that seemed to be a tribute to the nation attaining independence, he tore into a formidable attack that included Iftekhar Anjum, Riaz Afridi, Mansoor Amjad, Qaiser Abbas and Naved Latif, all of them Pakistan internationals at one stage or the other. In an innings punctuated by 10 fours and two sixes, ‘this guy’ scored 120 off 122 deliveries, putting on 207 for the second wicket with opener, fellow centurion and current India head coach Gautam Gambhir. It was a muscular exhibition of unfettered ball-striking, an exhibition that made us all forever fans. As if to show that that wasn’t a flash in the pan, he made a slightly more measured unbeaten 119 in the next league clash against Pakistan, and even though he produced just 15 in the final in which India conquered their arch-rivals, the legend of ‘this guy’ was inescapably, inevitably born. Mahendra Singh Dhoni’s decimation of Pakistan ‘A’ was a foretaste was what was to come. Grateful for the timely tip from the former India fast bowler, one was able to glimpse shades of the immense power and great maturity and game-awareness that nestled in his formidable frame. That ‘A’ tri-series was a bit of a novelty in that it was beamed on live television, a luxury reserved only for internationals at the time (and even now, though T20 leagues too are a regular feature). Nearly

22 years on, another ‘A’ tri-series has fired the imagination even before a ball has been bowled, thanks to the presence in the Indian side of a mercurial 15-year-old who has already become a household name in the cricketing world. **Foregone conclusion** Vaibhav Sooryavanshi’s inclusion in the Tilak Varma-led squad for the tournament that includes the developmental sides of Sri Lanka and Afghanistan was almost a foregone conclusion, given his exploits for Rajasthan Royals in the IPL. Last season, his first, threw up a 35-ball century (the second fastest in the tournament’s history), when the left-hander was but 14. This year, he snatched the Orange Cap with an extraordinary 776 runs at an otherworldly strike-rate of 237.30. Thrown in were two 15-ball half-centuries and a 36-ball hundred, as well as routine, nonchalant, irreverent decimation of the best fast bowlers in the world. How can you keep such a special talent out of the international game, never mind his tender age? How can you deprive audiences at the ground and those watching on television the opportunity to soak in this young lad parading his wares on a global canvas, entertaining and enthralling and exhilarating with his fearless batsmanship that is a gift from above, sure, but which has also been honed through hours and hours of single-minded practice that has staggered far wizened men? The clamour for his inclusion in the Indian T20 side reached a crescendo by the time Rajasthan crashed out of the tournament after losing to Shubman Gill’s Gujarat Titans in Qualifier 2. It’s not the worst idea to give the Indian Test and ODI skipper a first-hand reminder of the damage he can unleash, so Sooryavanshi donned his magic garb and lashed 96 off 47, with eight fours and seven sixes. It was another demonstration of his intelligence and street smartness, as much as his incandescent strokeplay. When he was dismissed in the 90s for the third time in four innings, the stadium felt his pain, even the opponents rued the four runs that got away. Such is the hold Sooryavanshi has on our collective consciousness. Sooryavanshi has already, unfairly, been saddled with comparisons to the peerless Sachin Tendulkar. Imagine that. The same Sachin Tendulkar who finished his career with more than 34,000 international runs and 100 international tons. The same Sachin Tendulkar, who carried the Indian batting on his shoulders for 24 years, from his debut in 1989 to his last appearance in 2013. The same Sachin Tendulkar, who brought a nation to a standstill when he strode out, bat in hand, to espouse the quality and class of Indian batting with an authority that comes only to the most gifted. One of the catalysts for this comparison is how both had already

The clamour for Sooryavanshi’s inclusion in the Indian T20 side reached a crescendo by the time Rajasthan crashed out of the IPL after losing to Gill’s Gujarat in Qualifier 2

grabbed the imagination at a very young age. Tendulkar hit the headlines during the record 664-run stand with Vinod Kambli in the Harris Shield, continued to wow the discerning Mumbai cricketing fraternity with his genius (obvious even when he was 14) and celebrated his Ranji Trophy, Duleep Trophy and Irani Cup debuts with centuries in each of those competitions. He shed tears of disappointment when he was overlooked for India’s tour of the West Indies in early 1989 and relished the prospect of taking on Imran Khan, Wasim Akram and Waqar Younis when he was finally selected for India’s first full series in Pakistan in more than a decade in November 1989. He shooed off physio Ali Irani despite bleeding from a blow to the nose from Waqar in the final Test in Sialkot to conjure a series-saving half-century, and destroyed Abdul Qadir in an exhibition match, smashing the living daylights out of the famed leg-spinner. All through his career, Tendulkar carried the burden of expectations lightly; it helped that he was his worst critic and was seized by the need to meet his own expectations, not of the others because each of the ‘others’ had a different expectation of him. **Undimmed inner light** Ravaged by injuries – sesamoid bone, tennis elbow, dodgy back, protesting groin – but driven by an undimmed inner light, he conquered peaks that appeared insurmountable, all with an equanimity that singled him out as the greatest Indian cricketer of his, potentially of all, time. How does one compare a 15-year-old who is yet to earn his first international cap with this certified champion, with one of the few on whom Bharat Ratna, the country’s greatest civilian honour, has been conferred? Let’s just let Sooryavanshi be. Let’s let him enjoy himself, and let us enjoy him enjoying himself. Let’s not live out our hopes and dreams vicariously through him because he already has enough to deal with and that is certain to only increase with time. Over the next two weeks in Dambulla, up in the north of Sri Lanka, Sooryavanshi will be squarely in the limelight, and in the crosshairs of the Sri Lankan and Afghan bowlers. No one likes to be smashed around, but very, very few have received stinging punishment from a 15-year-old who is exceptionally respectful of his elders so long as he doesn’t have a bat in his hands. By now, bowlers of all quality know full well the perils of being even slightly off their game when they bowl to him.

Mitchell Starc and Josh Hazlewood, Pat Cummins and Kagiso Rabada and Jasprit Bumrah and Rashid Khan have all suffered at his hands. If the mere mortals are shuddering in anticipatory trepidation, it’s not without good reason. Sooryavanshi will be treated differently because of how young he is. Already, the BCCI has permitted his parents to travel with him, both to Sri Lanka and to the United Kingdom later in the month, when he will be a part of the senior Indian team for the first time. That the India board will cover the parents’ travel and living expenses is a laudable initiative designed to send out the message that while there will be every effort to cash in on the goose that lays the golden eggs, it will be done so with empathy and understanding and not be driven purely by crass commercial greed and the lure of the greenbacks. One isn’t even sure if Sooryavanshi is aware of the magnitude of the fuss around him. The general belief is that he is all too aware, given how much more worldly-wise today’s 15-year-olds are. He is too smart not to realise that he is a special talent who is being given the special, preferential kid-glove treatment that his age merits. He knows that it’s just a matter of time before his bank balance surges, before the agents and the managers swarm him and before he is forced to shed his innocence and embrace wariness. The last two are the unfortunate but inevitable fallouts of courting attention and success this early, but neither Sooryavanshi nor the cricketing populace will have it any other way. As the sporting world braces for a bouquet of high-octane action – the FIFA World Cup starts on June 11 and the Women’s T20 World Cup gets underway the following day – it is impossible that in India, at the very least, and in several part of the cricketing globe, this relatively nondescript ‘A’ series will attract immense attention only for the presence of a generational talent. One suspects that the Hazlewoods and the Cummins’ might also park themselves in front of devices flashing live visuals, if only to see if the boy wonder subjects the relative ‘lesser lights’ to the same punishment he meted out to them during the IPL. There was ‘this guy’ in 2004. Now, there is ‘this boy’, a chronicled destroyer of reputations, egos and bowling figures. Single-handedly elevating the stature of an ‘A’ series that would otherwise have wallowed in anonymity but which has now gained a life of its own. Welcome to the world of Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, cricketing royalty in the making.

THE GIST

Sooryavanshi has already, unfairly, been saddled with comparisons to the peerless Tendulkar. One of the catalysts for this comparison is how both had grabbed the imagination at a very young age. As the sporting world braces for the FIFA World Cup and Women’s T20 World Cup, the relatively nondescript ‘A’ assignment in Sri Lanka will attract immense attention because of the wunderkind. By now, bowlers of all quality know full well the perils of being even slightly off their game when they bowl to the 15-year-old



‘Amplifying’ random numbers brings a breakthrough in digital security

Creating a truly unguessable password is difficult as even the best computers leave behind subtle, predictable patterns; by tapping into the power of quantum physics, scientists have now found a way to turn mostly random data into flawless security keys that are practically impossible to predict

Vasudevan Mukunth
CHENNAI

Most digital security relies today on random numbers to generate cryptographic keys. Think of a cryptographic key like a long, complex password. If that password is truly random, an attacker has to guess every possible combination. But if the ‘random’ process used to make that password has a pattern, the attacker can use that pattern to skip billions of guesses. Digital security has an Achilles’s heel: the numbers it uses for encryption are rarely as random as they seem. But in a study published in *Nature*, researchers at ETH Zürich have demonstrated a new solution called randomness amplification, where they used quantum physics to turn predictable bits of data into certifiably perfect randomness.

A note from the university said the researchers had effectively “generated certified perfect randomness for the first time”. Creating true randomness is actually really difficult. Most random number generators (RNGs) produce bits with a small bias. Say you’re flipping a coin that lands on ‘heads’ 51% of the time instead of 50%. That 1% difference is a bias.

Santha-Vazirani limit
In 1986, computer science researchers Miklós Santha and Umesh Vazirani showed that a classical computer cannot upgrade a weakly random source into a perfectly random one. Put another way, if a source of random numbers is predictable even in a small way, classical post-processing alone could never eliminate it. So if you give a classical computer a biased coin, any data it produces based on that coil will remain just as biased and predictable, no matter how much the computer tries to improve on the input. This is why even high-end random number generators suffer from experimental imperfections – like heat or electronic noise – that make their outcomes slightly biased, and thus predictable to an advanced attacker.

“Even modern random number generators, which are based on quantum mechanical effects like the reflection of photons from beam splitters, are not entirely immune to such a systematic error or bias,” Andreas Wallraff, one of the study’s lead investigators and and Laboratory for Solid-State Physics professor, said in the note. Over the last two decades, theoretical work has suggested that quantum physics may provide a workaround. In fact, in 2012, Roger Colbeck and Renato Renner – who is one of the authors of the new study – showed in theory that quantum physics could do it.

The ETH Zürich team achieved it using a Bell test, a physics experiment designed to prove a phenomenon called quantum entanglement. Entanglement is a state where two quantum particles – like atoms or photons – become linked such that a measurement performed on one particle instantly affects the other, no matter how far apart they are.

In a Bell test, two entangled particles are separated and measured. If the particles answer in a particular highly correlated way, it will show that the answers were not secretly decided in advance. In other words, the test will prove the universe itself did not know the answer until the moment the measurement happened.

Now, in quantum physics, the act of measuring something creates new information that wasn’t there before. For example, each of the two particles will be in a superposition of multiple states. When you measure one, it will collapse into one particular state – and so will the other entangled particle. This ‘final’ state is the new information.

Because this information is born at the exact instant of measurement, it is impossible for anyone to have known the outcome in advance. In the work, the team used this information as an additional source of randomness.

Quantum advantage
In their experiment, the team members entangled two particles, then placed them 30 m apart. This distance made sure the particles could not ‘cheat’ by communicating their ‘final’ states to each other at the speed of light.

Next, they used random biased bits to decide how to measure each particle. Then, with the measurement outcomes, they calculated the Bell violation score – a measure of how strongly the particles were entangled, and thus how clueless the universe might have been about the measurement outcomes. The score was 2.271.



Digital security has an Achilles heel: the numbers it uses for encryption are rarely as random as they seem. IMAGE CREATED WITH AI

This was above the classical limit of 2, meaning quantum physics rather than classical physics was in play. (Entanglement is a purely quantum phenomenon.)

“It is a clean instance of quantum advantage: a task quantum physics performs that classical physics provably cannot,” Marin Ivezic, founder of research-driven consulting firm Applied Quantum, wrote on his site.

However, the highest score quantum physics allows is 2.82. And the closer an experiment gets to this value, the stronger the evidence that the particles are behaving according to quantum physics alone rather than also being influenced by bias. In a lab, stray heat, microscopic timing errors, and other subtle factors can create noise that biases the particles in small ways. And an attacker who understands the specific noise in a setup might notice that when the system glitches, it tends to produce a ‘1’ more often than a ‘0’, and use that to their advantage.

The researchers now had two resources: the original random biased bits and the new outcomes from the Bell test. They combined both using a mathematical tool called a two-source extractor. Its purpose is to blend two independent strings of data. Independent means knowing anything about String 1 must reveal nothing about String 2, and vice versa.

The extractor is designed so that if an attacker has a slight advantage in predicting String 1 and a slight advantage in predicting String 2, they have zero advantage in predicting the combination. The extractor achieves this by cancelling the strings’ individual biases out as long as they are independent.

In their tests, the researchers worked with 5.3 billion random biased bits and 2.6 billion bits of information from the measurements.

They combined them in 1.3 billion trials, which they ran at 50,000 times per second over nine hours. At the end of each trial, the extractor output was 45 million bits – all purely random. The rest got pruned away because they were biased information or noise.

“The resulting sequence of zeros and ones is now really perfectly random, and we can even certify that,” Prof. Renner, a professor at the Institute for Theoretical Physics at ETH Zürich, said in the note. The certificate is the Bell test score.

“The technical improvements allowed us, for the first time, to create random numbers that will remain perfectly random for all eternity – no matter what

In quantum physics, the act of measuring something creates new information that wasn’t there before; because this information is born at the exact instant of measurement, it is impossible for anyone to have known the outcome in advance, becoming an additional source of randomness

analytical methods are used to assess their randomness,” Prof. Renner added.

The team also said their protocol to generate purely random numbers is device-independent – a gold standard in security that means even if you don’t trust the person who built the hardware, even if you don’t fully understand how the machine works, you can trust the output to be random.

In physics, it is mathematically impossible for a classical theory to score higher than 2 on a Bell test. By scoring 2.271 on the test, then, the researchers’ setup proved it was producing random quantum information. That said, according to the team’s security analysis, the protocol has a failure probability of one in a trillion, similar to flipping a coin and getting ‘heads’ 40 times in a row. This is because of the number of tests, 1.3 billion. If they had conducted several billion more, the researchers may have reduced the failure rate to one in a quadrillion or quintillion. It is mathematically impossible to reach 100%.

In fact, the researchers had chosen one in a trillion as their finish line. And to reach that level of certainty with a score of 2.271, they had to discard a large amount of data in the end. If their score had been higher, they could have reached the same failure rate while keeping much more of the data.

While one in a trillion suffices for practical applications, the experiment’s apparatus can’t yet replace conventional random-number generators. First, it is complex and resource-intensive. Its randomness output is modest compared to commercial systems: around 1,400 bits per second versus 1 billion bits per second. It is also information-wise inefficient in that for every 119 “almost perfectly random” bits it consumed, it produced 1 “certified random” bit – whereas commercial generators produce a very large number of “almost perfectly random” bits from just one “somewhat random” bit.

But while the new protocol is slower

and less efficient, it can produce randomness of a higher quality. That is, the work establishes that randomness can be amplified in lab conditions, that too in a device-independent way. It also proves the Santha-Wazirani limit can be broken by quantum physics.

Beacon of randomness
“My understanding is that the main advance here is not device-independent random-number generation *per se*. That has already been demonstrated using ... Bell tests,” Urbasi Sinha, head of the Quantum Information and Computing lab at the Raman Research Institute, Bengaluru, told *The Hindu*. “The new element is the experimental demonstration of device-independent randomness amplification: starting with a weak, imperfect source of randomness and using quantum correlations to certify output bits that are unbiased under the stated model.”

“This is significant because practical quantum random-number generators are never ideal, and in our own work on QRNGs and semi-device-independent certification, we have also emphasised that the real issue is not whether a bit string passes statistical tests but whether its unpredictability can be certified from clearly stated physical assumptions,” she added.

“The important caveat is that the guarantee here is conditional on the Santha-Vazirani weak-source model, the claimed bias bound on the input randomness, the... Bell-test implementation, and the validity of the extractor/security analysis.”

The researchers proposed one application: a public randomness beacon – a service that broadcasts certified random bits for uses ranging from financial transactions and blockchain protocols to military encryption. The U.S. National Institute of Standards and Technology already runs a service where it releases 512 random bits every 60 seconds on its website. They are used in lotteries, to assign juries, to sample voting machines, and for research.

That said, Mr. Ivezic cautioned in his write-up that while certifiable randomness could help security today, it will not help protect encrypted information against attacks by future quantum computers.

“Better randomness was never the answer to that problem,” he wrote; “migrating to post-quantum algorithms is.” India recently took its very first steps on this front. (mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in)



Mustard is the most vital crop to meet India’s deficit of edible oils. FILE PHOTO

New mustard hybrids need diverse farming plans

Vasudevan Mukunth

In the 2026-27 rabi sowing season, from October to April, Indian farmers are set to begin the wide-scale cultivation of imidazolinone-resistant (IMI-resistant) mustard hybrids. These hybrids are designed to overcome a parasitic weed called Orobanche, a major hurdle in oilseed production.

India has long grappled with an edible oils deficit. In 2024-25, the country imported around 16 million tonnes at about ₹1.6 lakh crore. Mustard is the most vital oilseed crop to meet this demand, especially in the arid environments of North India. However, its yields have been suppressed throughout the year by Orobanche, a destructive root parasite that attaches to the mustard plant and drains it of water and nutrients. (It has more recently been called Phelipanche.)

The new IMI-resistant hybrids are a technological solution to this problem. Unlike genetically modified (GM) crops, these hybrids were developed in a process called mutation breeding – where scientists breed crops to preserve certain natural mutations. The process is based on an enzyme called acetolactate synthase (ALS), which is essential for plant growth. Normal mustard plants are killed by IMI herbicides because the herbicides inhibit ALS.

In the new IMI-resistant hybrids, a single change in the plant’s DNA rendered the ALS enzyme resistant to the herbicide, freeing farmers to spray IMI herbicides directly over the field, killing only the weeds. This strategy is particularly effective against Orobanche because, as the herbicide moves through the soil and the plant, it strikes the parasite where manual weeding can’t reach.

Farmers have welcomed these hybrids because they don’t increase the demand for labour exactly when it might be unavailable, especially in the narrow window when weeding is necessary, and the research community because it protects oilseeds.

However, some experts have urged caution over their long-term use. In a commentary recently published in the journal *Current Science*, Deepak Pental, a leading geneticist at the University of Delhi, acknowledged the immediate benefits but also said the technology must be managed with care to prevent the weeds from evolving their own resistance.

Prof. Pental explained that if farmers rely on only one type of herbicide year after year, the “strong directional selection” will lead to “the emergence of resistant or less susceptible weed populations, the erosion of herbicide efficacy, and ultimately the strategic failure of the production system built around that chemistry”.

To that end, he wrote that the introduction of these new crops should not be viewed as a simple trade-off, where chemicals merely replace manual labour, but as a “challenge” that requires a variety of weed-control methods. Specifically, for the technology to remain viable for more than a few years, it must be part of a broader, more diverse farming strategy that includes rotating crops, using different types of herbicides with various modes of action, and continuing to use manual weeding to remove any weeds that survive the chemical spray. “A single herbicide mode of action cannot be the foundation of a sustainable weed management strategy in any agriculture,” Prof. Pental wrote.

As India rolls out IMI-resistant mustard this season, the new challenge for the agricultural enterprise will be to ensure these powerful new tools become part of a “durable, and evolutionarily informed” programme rather than a quick fix.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

India's account surplus in the fourth quarter of FY26

7.1 in \$ billion. The surplus stood at \$13.7 billion, or 1.4% of GDP, in the fourth quarter of 2024-25. However, for the entire fiscal year, the current account deficit stood at \$25.2 billion, or 0.6% of GDP, compared to \$22.9 billion during 2024-25. Services exports increased on a year-on-year basis in major categories, such as computer services and business services. PTI

Trinamool MPs who are to write to Speaker backing NDA

20 Twenty Lok Sabha MPs have decided to write to Speaker Om Birla declaring support for the BJP-led NDA. The development comes days after the Trinamool leadership suffered a setback in the West Bengal Assembly, where 58 of its 80 MLAs defied the party high command's decision to appoint Sovandeb Chattopadhyay as the Leader of the Opposition. PTI

Number of Andhra Pradesh lands resurveyed

6,500 Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu on Monday said that land resurvey has been completed in over 6,500 villages across the State, enabling the government to update the land records. He noted that pattardar passbooks (land documents) have been issued to 26.4 lakh people. PTI

Indians languishing in Bangladeshi prisons after completing terms

148 A prison official said 152 foreigners, including 148 Indians, were languishing in Bangladeshi prisons even though they had completed their jail terms, according to prison statistics published six months ago. The inmates could not be released as their identities remain unverified, while attempts to contact the Indian Embassy yielded no response, the report said. PTI

Current manpower shortage in Tamil Nadu Electricity Board

70,000 Tamil Nadu Electricity Minister R Nirmal Kumar on Monday announced that the State's electricity board will recruit at least 15,000 permanent employees this year to address severe manpower shortages in the power apparatus. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

Follow us facebook.com/thehindu X.com/the_hindu instagram.com/the_hindu

What is lost and gained in NFHS-6

NFHS-6 records gains in child nutrition, maternal care, institutional births and women's Internet use, while also introducing new questions on digital literacy and direct benefit transfers; but the survey's preliminary fact sheet is thinner than the last round, dropping key indicators such as anaemia, mortality, sex ratio at birth

ECONOMIC NOTES

Areena Arora

India's latest National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6) records gains in child nutrition, maternal care, institutional births and women's Internet use. But its preliminary fact sheet is also thinner than the last round, with 101 indicators compared with 131 in NFHS-5.

Which indicators were removed from NFHS-6?

Key indicators such as anaemia, mortality, sex ratio at birth, sanitation, and clean cooking fuel have been removed from the survey.

The Union Health Ministry released the fact sheets of NFHS-6 on May 29, covering 2023-24. The survey recorded data from nearly 6.8 lakh households across every State and Union Territory except Manipur.

Preliminary findings report clear gains on several measures, including mothers getting at least four antenatal check-ups, up about seven percentage points from NFHS-5, an increase in institutional births and women's Internet usage. It also points to declines in several metrics, such as exclusive breastfeeding of infants under six months, down nearly eight percentage points, and the use of modern contraception, down to 52.7% from 56.4%.

The NFHS is commissioned by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, which designates the International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) to conduct the survey. Over the years, the scope of the survey has been additive by design, retaining the previous questionnaire and adding to it.

NFHS-4 in 2015-16 introduced district-level estimates and tablet-based digital interviewing for survey collection. NFHS-5 pushed the indicators further, including new topics, such as preschool education, disability, access to a toilet facility, death registration, bathing practices during menstruation and methods and reasons for abortion. It also extended blood pressure and blood sugar measurements from adults aged between 15 and 49 to all adults aged 15 and above. The survey measured 131 key indicators, up from 114 in NFHS-4.

While the HIV testing component was dropped from NFHS-5, it retained questions on HIV/AIDS knowledge, attitudes, prior testing, sexually transmitted infections, and sexual behaviour. In NFHS-6, biological HIV testing has been brought back as part of the clinical, anthropometric and biochemical testing schedule.

The NFHS-6 fact sheet does not separately spell out whether all HIV/AIDS knowledge and attitude questions were retained.

NFHS-6 also added new questions on direct benefit transfers, self-help group memberships, digital literacy and financial transactions. It also includes testing for Hepatitis-B and Hepatitis-C among women and men, as well as dried blood spot collection from children aged 4-5 for Hepatitis-B testing.

But for the first time, the survey has also subtracted overall, showing a net reduction of 30 indicators in the preliminary results. Among the dropped indicators, the most notable ones, such as anaemia, infant and child mortality, sex ratio at birth, clean cooking fuel use, and sanitation, have all appeared since at least NFHS-4.



The NFHS is commissioned by the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, which designates the IIPS to conduct the survey. GETTY IMAGES

Why was anaemia dropped?

The case for removing anaemia is related to how it was measured. The indicator had long shown a worsening picture. Between NFHS-4 in 2015-16 and NFHS-5 in 2019-21, anaemia rose across the board. Among children, anaemia prevalence went up from 58.6% to 67.1%, among women aged 15-49, it rose from 53.1% to 57%, and among pregnant women, anaemia rose from 50.4% to 52.2%.

The rise in anaemia was near-universal across the country, with child anaemia increasing in 28 States and Union Territories, and in some cases by big leaps, from 35.7% to 68.4% in Assam and 19.3% to 46.4% in Mizoram. Such deterioration was reported despite the government launching the Anaemia Mukh Bharat campaign in 2018, aimed at tackling anaemia. The reason for dropping it as an indicator then boiled down to how the data were being collected.

NFHS measured haemoglobin from a finger-prick blood sample read on a portable analyser, which several nutrition researchers contend overstated anaemia compared to the venous blood drawn by other surveys. IIPS dropped the anaemia questionnaire when NFHS-6 fieldwork began in 2023. The official position is that the condition will now be tracked separately, through a dedicated Diet and Biomarkers Survey under the National Institute of Nutrition using a method its proponents consider more accurate.

The Diet and Biomarkers Survey in India was not a hurried replacement and was launched in December 2022, before NFHS-6 fieldwork began, at the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition in Hyderabad.

The survey recorded data on individual

dietary intake across age groups, paired with blood and urine biomarkers.

It also built upon nutrition deficiencies and tracked obesity alongside anaemia, a first, according to the organisers. For anaemia, data were collected from venous blood instead of the finger-prick method that NFHS used. Data collection is complete, but hasn't been released yet.

What other changes were made?

A line-by-line comparison of the two fact sheets from NFHS-5 and NFHS-6 shows that the net fall of 30 actually combines 43 indicators dropped and 13 added. Several of the deletions were long-running series, and a few are closely related to the government's signature programmes.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi's government in 2019 had announced that India would be open defecation-free. NFHS-5 recorded 70% of the country's population living in households with access to sanitation facilities. That data point has also been dropped.

The share of households using clean fuel for cooking, 58.6% in NFHS-5, is gone – a direct measure of the success of the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana.

The three mortality indicators – neonatal, infant and under-five – have also been cut, but these will be tracked by the Sample Registration System, whose latest bulletin put infant mortality at 24 per 1,000 live births.

The Registration System, however, does not carry district-level data and socio-economic breakdowns that are available in NFHS.

The sex ratio of the total population and the sex ratio at birth, 929 females per 1,000 males in NFHS-5, are both absent, removing a standard signal of sex-selective practices. Four

cancer-screening indicators, covering cervical, breast and oral cancer, introduced only in NFHS-5 are gone after a single round.

A few changes are redefinitions rather than cuts. Women's individual ownership of a house or land has become a household-level measure. Three-dose hepatitis B line has become a birth-dose measure, and pre-school attendance has shifted age bands, targeting a younger demographic. IIPS has not published a rationale for the wider list.

Together, the removals leave no current survey-based national figure for infant mortality, sanitation coverage, sex ratio at birth, cancer screening rates or comprehensive HIV knowledge, gaps that no other single source fills at the same scale.

How did survey results change between NFHS-5 and NFHS-6?

NFHS-6 reported a drop in the number of women who have experienced spousal violence, down to 22.3% from 29.3%. The number of children aged five or below who are stunted declined too. The drop from NFHS-4 to NFHS-5 was just under three percentage points, but NFHS-6 saw a drop of over six percentage points.

State-level changes are sharper for certain indicators.

Health insurance coverage rose the most in West Bengal, from 33.7% of households in NFHS-5 to 88.2% in NFHS-6. Women's Internet use saw its largest increase in Andhra Pradesh, from 21% to 63.6%. Haryana recorded the steepest fall in exclusive breastfeeding among infants under six months, from 69.5% to 41.2%. The share of women classified as overweight or obese increased in every State.

THE GIST

▼ NFHS-6 shows a net reduction of 30 indicators in its preliminary fact sheet, with 43 indicators dropped and 13 added compared with NFHS-5.

▼ Anaemia was dropped from NFHS-6, with the official position being that it will be tracked separately through the Diet and Biomarkers Survey.

▼ Several long-running indicators, including infant and child mortality, sex ratio at birth, sanitation coverage, clean cooking fuel use and cancer-screening measures, are absent from the latest fact sheet, leaving gaps that no other single source fills at the same scale.

